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The Doctrine of Fascism

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Like all sound political conceptions, Fascism is action and it is thought; action in which doctrine is immanent, and doctrine arising from a given system of historical forces in which it is inserted, and working on them from within.¹ It has therefore a form correlated to contingencies of time and space; but it has also an ideal content which makes it an expression of truth in the higher region of the history of thought.² There is no way of exercising a spiritual influence in the world as a human will dominating the will of others, unless one has a conception both of the transient and the specific reality on which that action is to be exercised, and of the permanent and universal reality in which the transient dwells and has its being. To know men one must know man; and to know man one must be acquainted with reality and its laws. There can be no conception of the State which is not fundamentally a conception of life: philosophy or intuition, system of ideas evolving within the framework of logic or concentrated in a vision or a faith, but always, at least potentially, an organic conception of the world.

Thus many of the practical expressions of Fascism such as party organization, system of education, and discipline can only be understood when considered in relation to its general attitude toward life. A spiritual attitude.³ Fascism sees in the world not only those superficial, material aspects in which man appears as an individual, standing by himself, self-centered, subject to natural law, which instinctively urges him toward a life of selfish momentary pleasure; it sees not only the individual but the nation and the country; individuals and generations bound together by a moral law, with common traditions and a mission which suppressing the instinct for life closed in a brief circle of pleasure, builds up a higher life, founded on duty, a life free from the limitations of time and space, in which the individual, by self-sacrifice, the renunciation of self-interest, by death itself, can achieve that purely spiritual existence in which his value as a man consists.

The conception is therefore a spiritual one, arising from the general reaction of the century against the materialistic positivism of the XIXth century. Anti-positivistic but positive; neither skeptical nor agnostic; neither pessimistic nor supinely optimistic as are, generally speaking, the doctrines (all negative) which place the center of life outside man; whereas, by the exercise of his free will, man can and must create his own world.

Fascism wants man to be active and to engage in action with all his energies; it wants him to be manfully aware of the difficulties besetting him and ready to face them. It conceives of life as a struggle in which it behooves a man to win for himself a really worthy place, first of all by fitting himself (physically, morally, intellectually) to become the implement required for winning it. As for the individual, so for the nation, and so for mankind.⁴ Hence the high value of culture in all its forms (artistic, religious, scientific)⁵ and the outstanding importance of

education. Hence also the essential value of work, by which man subjugates nature and creates the human world (economic, political, ethical, and intellectual).

This positive conception of life is obviously an ethical one. It invests the whole field of reality as well as the human activities which master it. No action is exempt from moral judgment; no activity can be despoiled of the value which a moral purpose confers on all things. Therefore life, as conceived of by the Fascist, is serious, austere, and religious; all its manifestations are poised in a world sustained by moral forces and subject to spiritual responsibilities. The Fascist disdains an "easy" life.⁶

The Fascist conception of life is a religious one,⁷ in which man is viewed in his immanent relation to a higher law, endowed with an objective will transcending the individual and raising him to conscious membership of a spiritual society. "Those who perceive nothing beyond opportunistic considerations in the religious policy of the Fascist regime fail to realize that Fascism is not only a system of government but also and above all a system of thought.

In the Fascist conception of history, man is man only by virtue of the spiritual process to which he contributes as a member of the family, the social group, the nation, and in function of history to which all nations bring their contribution. Hence the great value of tradition in records, in language, in customs, in the rules of social life.⁸ Outside history man is a nonentity. Fascism is therefore opposed to all individualistic abstractions based on eighteenth century materialism; and it is opposed to all Jacobinistic utopias and innovations. It does not believe in the possibility of "happiness" on earth as conceived by the economic literature of the XVIIIth century, and it therefore rejects the theological notion that at some future time the human family will secure a final settlement of all its difficulties. This notion runs counter to experience which teaches that life is in continual flux and in process of evolution. In politics Fascism aims at realism; in practice it desires to deal only with those problems which are the spontaneous product of historic conditions and which find or suggest their own solutions.⁹ Only by entering in to the process of reality and taking possession of the forces at work within it, can man act on man and on nature.¹⁰

Anti-individualistic, the Fascist conception of life stresses the importance of the State and accepts the individual only in so far as his interests coincide with those of the State, which stands for the conscience and the universal, will of man as a historic entity.¹¹ It is opposed to classical liberalism which arose as a reaction to absolutism and exhausted its historical function when the State became the expression of the conscience and will of the people. Liberalism denied the State in the name of the individual; Fascism reasserts

The rights of the State as expressing the real essence of the individual.¹² And if liberty is to be the attribute of living men and not of abstract dummies invented by individualistic liberalism, then Fascism stands for liberty, and for the only liberty worth having, the liberty of the State and of the individual within the State.¹³ The Fascist conception of the State is all embracing; outside of it no human or spiritual values can exist, much less have value. Thus understood, Fascism, is totalitarian, and the Fascist State—a synthesis and a unit inclusive of all values—interprets, develops, and potentates the whole life of a people.¹⁴

No individuals or groups (political parties, cultural associations, economic unions, social classes) outside the State.¹⁵ Fascism is therefore opposed to Socialism to which unity within the State (which amalgamates classes into a single economic and ethical reality) is unknown, and which sees in history nothing but the class

struggle. Fascism is likewise opposed to trade unionism as a class weapon. But when brought within the orbit of the State, Fascism recognizes the real needs which gave rise to socialism and trade unionism, giving them due weight in the guild or corporative system in which divergent interests are coordinated and harmonized in the unity of the State.¹⁶

Grouped according to their several interests, individuals form classes; they form trade-unions when organized according to their several economic activities; but first and foremost they form the State, which is no mere matter of numbers, the sum of the individuals forming the majority. Fascism is therefore opposed to that form of democracy which equates a nation to the majority, lowering it to the level of the largest number¹⁷; but it is the purest form of democracy if the nation be considered as it should be from the point of view of quality rather than quantity, as an idea, the mightiest because the most ethical, the most coherent, the truest, expressing itself in a people as the conscience and will of the few, if not, indeed, of one, and ending to express itself in the conscience and the will of the mass, of the whole group ethnically molded by natural and historical conditions into a nation, advancing, as one conscience and one will, along the self same line of development and spiritual formation.¹⁸ Not a race, nor a geographically defined region, but a people, historically perpetuating itself; a multitude unified by an idea and imbued with the will to live, the will to power, self-consciousness, personality.¹⁹

In so far as it is embodied in a State, this higher personality becomes a nation. It is not the nation which generates the State; that is an antiquated naturalistic concept which afforded a basis for XIXth century publicity in favor of national governments. Rather is it the State which creates the nation, conferring volition and therefore real life on a people made aware of their moral unity.

The right to national independence does not arise from any merely literary and idealistic form of self-consciousness; still less from a more or less passive and unconscious *de facto* situation, but from an active, self-conscious, political will expressing itself in action and ready to prove its rights. It arises, in short, from the existence, at least virtually, of a State. Indeed, it is the State which, as the expression of a universal ethical will, creates the right to national independence.²⁰

A nation, as expressed in the State, is a living, ethical entity only in so far as it is progressive. Inactivity is death. Therefore the State is not only Authority which governs and confers legal form and spiritual value on individual wills, but it is also Power which makes its will felt and respected beyond its own frontiers, thus affording practical proof of the universal character of the decisions necessary to ensure its development. This implies organization and expansion, potential if not actual. Thus the State equates itself to the will of man, whose development cannot be checked by obstacles and which, by achieving self-expression, demonstrates its infinity.²¹

The Fascist State, as a higher and more powerful expression of personality, is a force, but a spiritual one. It sums up all the manifestations of the moral and intellectual life of man. Its functions cannot therefore be limited to those of enforcing order and keeping the peace, as the liberal doctrine had it. It is no mere mechanical device for defining the sphere within which the individual may duly exercise his supposed rights. The Fascist State is an inwardly accepted standard and rule of conduct, a discipline of the whole person; it permeates the will no less than the intellect. It stands for a principle which becomes the central motive of man as a member of civilized society, sinking deep down into his personality; it

dwells in the heart of the man of action and of the thinker, of the artist and of the man of science: soul of the soul.²²

Fascism, in short, is not only a law-giver and a founder of institutions, but an educator and a promoter of spiritual life. It aims at refashioning not only the forms of life but their content—man, his character, and his faith. To achieve this propose it enforces discipline and uses authority, entering into the soul and ruling with undisputed sway. Therefore it has chosen as its emblem the Lictor's rods, the symbol of unity, strength, and justice.

POLITICAL AND SOCIAL DOCTRINE

When in the now distant March of 1919, speaking through the columns of the *Popolo d'Italia* I summoned to Milan the surviving interventionists who had intervened, and who had followed me ever since the foundation of the Fasci of revolutionary action in January 1915, I had in mind no specific doctrinal program. The only doctrine of which I had practical experience was that of socialism, from 1903-04 until the winter of 1914—nearly a decade. My experience was that both of a follower and a leader—but it was not doctrinal experience. My doctrine during that period had been the doctrine of action. A uniform, universally accepted doctrine of Socialism had not existed since 1905, when the revisionist movement, headed by Bernstein, arose in Germany, countered by the formation, in the see-saw of tendencies, of a left revolutionary movement which in Italy never quitted the field of phrases, whereas, in the case of Russian socialism, it became the prelude to Bolshevism.

Reformism, revolutionism, centrism, the very echo of that terminology is dead, while in the great river of Fascism one can trace currents which had their source in Sorel, Peguy, Lagardelle of the Movement Socialists, and in the cohort of Italian syndicalist who from 1904 to 1914 brought a new note into the Italian socialist environment—previously emasculated and chloroformed by fornicating with Giolitti's party—a note sounded in Olivetti's *Pagine Libere*, Orano's *Lupa*, Enrico Leone's *Divenirs Socials*.

When the war ended in 1919 Socialism, as a doctrine, was already dead; it continued to exist only as a grudge, especially in Italy where its only chance lay in inciting to reprisals against the men who had willed the war and who were to be made to pay for it.

The *Popolo d'Italia* described itself in its subtitle as the daily organ of fighters and producers. The word producer was already the expression of a mental trend. Fascism was not the nursling of a doctrine previously drafted at a desk; it was born of the need of action, and was action; it was not a party but, in the first two years, an anti-party and a movement. The name I gave the organization fixed its character.

Yet if anyone cares to reread the now crumpled sheets of those days giving an account of the meeting at which the Italian Fasci di combattimento were founded, he will find not a doctrine but a series of pointers, forecasts, hints which, when freed from the inevitable matrix of contingencies, were to develop in a few years time into a series of doctrinal positions entitling Fascism to rank as a political doctrine differing from all others, past or present.

“If the bourgeoisie—I then said—believe that they have found in us their lightning-conductors, they are mistaken. We must go towards the people We wish the working classes to accustom themselves to the responsibilities of

management so that they may realize that it is no easy matter to run a business We will fight both technical and spiritual rear-guardism Now that the succession of the re-gime is open we must not be fainthearted. We must rush forward; if the present regime is to be superseded we must take its place. The right of succession is ours, for we urged the country to enter the war and we led it to victory The existing forms of political representation cannot satisfy us; we want direct representation of the several interests It may be objected that this program implies a return to the guilds (*corporazioni*). No matter! I therefore hope this assembly will accept the economic claims advanced by national syndicalism

Is it not strange that from the very first day, at Piazza San Sepolcro, the word “guild” (*corporazione*) was pronounced, a word which, as the Revolution developed, was to express one of the basic legislative and social creations of the regime?

The years preceding the March on Rome cover a period during which the need of action forbade delay and careful doctrinal elaborations. Fighting was going on in the towns and villages. There were discussions but ... there was something more sacred and more important: Death Fascists knew how to die. A doctrine—fully elaborated, divided up into chapters and paragraphs with annotations, may have been lacking, but it was replaced by something far more decisive,—by a faith. All the same, if with the help of books, articles, resolutions passed at congresses, major and minor speeches, anyone should care to revive the memory of those days, he will find, provided he knows how to seek and select, that the doctrinal foundations were laid while the battle was still raging. Indeed, it was during those years that Fascist thought armed, refined itself, and proceeded ahead with its organization. The problems of the individual and the State; the problems of authority and liberty; political, social, and more especially national problems were discussed; the conflict with liberal, democratic, socialistic, Masonic doctrines and with those of the Partito Popolare, was carried on at the same time as the punitive expeditions. Nevertheless, the lack of a formal system was used by disingenuous adversaries as an argument for proclaiming Fascism incapable of elaborating a doctrine at the very time when that doctrine was being formulated—no matter how tumultuously—first, as is the case with all new ideas, in the guise of violent dogmatic negations; then in the more positive guise of constructive theories, subsequently incorporated, in 1926, 1927, and 1928, in the laws and institutions of the regime.

Fascism is now clearly defined not only as a regime but as a doctrine. This means that Fascism, exercising its critical faculties on itself and on others, has studied from its own special standpoint and judged by its own standards all the problems affecting the material and intellectual interests now causing such grave anxiety to the nations of the world, and is ready to deal with them by its own policies.

First of all, as regards the future development of mankind, and quite apart from all present political considerations. Fascism does not, generally speaking, believe in the possibility or utility of perpetual peace. It therefore discards pacifism as a cloak for cowardly supine renunciation in contradistinction to self-sacrifice. War alone keys up all human energies to their maximum tension and sets the seal of nobility on those peoples who have the courage to face it. All other tests are substitutes which never place a man face to face with himself before the alternative of life or death. Therefore all doctrines which postulate peace at all costs are incompatible with Fascism. Equally foreign to the spirit of Fascism, even if accepted as useful in meeting special political situations—are all internationalistic or League superstructures which, as history shows, crumble to

the ground whenever the heart of nations is deeply stirred by sentimental, idealistic or practical considerations. Fascism carries this anti-pacifistic attitude into the life of the individual. "I don't care a damn" (*me ne frega*)—the proud motto of the fighting squads scrawled by a wounded man on his bandages, is not only an act of philosophic stoicism, it sums up a doctrine which is not merely political: it is evidence of a fighting spirit which accepts all risks. It signifies new style of Italian life. The Fascist accepts and loves life; he rejects and despises suicide as cowardly. Life as he understands it means duty, elevation, conquest; life must be lofty and full, it must be lived for oneself but above all for others, both near by and far off, present and future.

The population policy of the regime is the consequence of these premises. The Fascist loves his neighbor, but the word "neighbor" does not stand for some vague and unseizable conception. Love of one's neighbor does not exclude necessary educational severity; still less does it exclude differentiation and rank. Fascism will have nothing to do with universal embraces; as a member of the community of nations it looks other peoples straight in the eyes; it is vigilant and on its guard; it follows others in all their manifestations and notes any changes in their interests; and it does not allow itself to be deceived by mutable and fallacious appearances.

Such a conception of life makes Fascism the resolute negation of the doctrine underlying so-called scientific and Marxian socialism, the doctrine of historic materialism which would explain the history of mankind in terms of the class struggle and by changes in the processes and instruments of production, to the exclusion of all else.

That the vicissitudes of economic life—discoveries of raw materials, new technical processes, and scientific inventions—have their importance, no one denies; but that they suffice to explain human history to the exclusion of other factors is absurd. Fascism believes now and always in sanctity and heroism, that is to say in acts in which no economic motive—remote or immediate—is at work. Having denied historic materialism, which sees in men mere puppets on the surface of history, appearing and disappearing on the crest of the waves while in the depths the real directing forces move and work, Fascism also denies the immutable and irreparable character of the class struggle which is the natural outcome of this economic conception of history; above all it denies that the class struggle is the preponderating agent in social transformations. Having thus struck a blow at socialism in the two main points of its doctrine, all that remains of it is the sentimental aspiration—old as humanity itself—toward social relations in which the sufferings and sorrows of the humbler folk will be alleviated. But here again Fascism rejects the economic interpretation of felicity as something to be secured socialistically, almost automatically, at a given stage of economic evolution when all will be assured a maximum of material comfort. Fascism denies the materialistic conception of happiness as a possibility, and abandons it to the economists of the mid-eighteenth century. This means that Fascism denies the equation: Well-being = Happiness, which sees in men mere animals, content when they can feed and fatten, thus reducing them to a vegetative existence pure and simple.

After socialism, Fascism trains its guns on the whole block of democratic ideologies, and rejects both their premises and their practical applications and implements. Fascism denies that numbers, as such, can be the determining factor in human society; it denies the right of numbers to govern by means of periodical consultations; it asserts the irremediable and fertile and beneficent inequality of

men who cannot be leveled by any such mechanical and extrinsic device as universal suffrage. Democratic regimes may be described as those under which the people are, from time to time, deluded into the belief that they exercise sovereignty, while all the time real sovereignty resides in and is exercised by other and sometimes irresponsible and secret forces. Democracy is a kingless regime infested by many kings who are sometimes more exclusive, tyrannical, and destructive than one, even if he be a tyrant. This explains why Fascism—although, for contingent reasons, it was republican in tendency prior to 1922—abandoned that stand before the March on Rome, convinced that the form of government is no longer a matter of preeminent importance, and because the study of past and present monarchies and past and present republics shows that neither monarchy nor republic can be judged *sub specie aeternitatis*, but that each stands for a form of government expressing the political evolution, the history, the traditions, and the psychology of a given country.

Fascism has outgrown the dilemma: monarchy versus republic, over which democratic regimes too long dallied, attributing all insufficiencies to the former and proving the latter as a regime of perfection, whereas experience teaches that some republics are inherently reactionary and absolutist while some monarchies accept the most daring political and social experiments.

In one of his philosophic Meditations Renan—who had pre-fascist intuitions—remarks, “Reason and science are the products of mankind, but it is chimerical to seek reason directly for the people and through the people. It is not essential to the existence of reason that all should be familiar with it; and even if all had to be initiated, this could not be achieved through democracy which seems fated to lead to the extinction of all arduous forms of culture and all highest forms of learning. The maxim that society exists only for the well-being and freedom of the individuals composing it does not seem to be in conformity with nature's plans, which care only for the species and seem ready to sacrifice the individual. It is much to be feared that the last word of democracy thus understood (and let me hasten to add that it is susceptible of a different interpretation) would be a form of society in which a degenerate mass would have no thought beyond that of enjoying the ignoble pleasures of the vulgar.”

In rejecting democracy Fascism rejects the absurd conventional lie of political equalitarianism, the habit of collective irresponsibility, the myth of felicity and indefinite progress. But if democracy be understood as meaning a regime in which the masses are not driven back to the margin of the State, and then the writer of these pages has already defined Fascism as an organized, centralized, authoritarian democracy.

Fascism is definitely and absolutely opposed to the doctrines of liberalism, both in the political and the economic sphere. The importance of liberalism in the XIXth century should not be exaggerated for present day polemical purposes, nor should we make of one of the many doctrines which flourished in that century a religion for mankind for the present and for all time to come. Liberalism really flourished for fifteen years only. It arose in 1830 as a reaction to the Holy Alliance which tried to force Europe to recede further back than 1789; it touched its zenith in 1848 when even Pius IXth was a liberal. Its decline began immediately after that year. If 1848 was a year of light and poetry, 1849 was a year of darkness and tragedy. The Roman Republic was killed by a sister republic, that of France. In that same year Marx, in his famous *Communist Manifesto*, launched the gospel of socialism.

In 1851 Napoleon III made his illiberal coup d'etat and ruled France until 1870 when he was turned out by a popular rising following one of the severest military defeats known to history. The victor was Bismarck who never even knew the whereabouts of liberalism and its prophets. It is symptomatic that throughout the XIXth century the religion of liberalism was completely unknown to so highly civilized a people as the Germans but for one parenthesis which has been described as the "ridiculous parliament of Frankfurt" which lasted just one season. Germany attained her national unity outside liberalism and in opposition to liberalism, a doctrine which seems foreign to the German temperament, essentially monarchical, whereas liberalism is the historic and logical anteroom to anarchy. The three stages in the making of German unity were the three wars of 1864, 1866, and 1870, led by such "liberals" as Moltke and Bismarck. And in the upbuilding of Italian unity liberalism played a very minor part when compared to the contribution made by Mazzini and Garibaldi who were not liberals. But for the intervention of the illiberal Napoleon III we should not have had Lombardy, and without that of the illiberal Bismarck at Sadowa and at Sedan very probably we should not have had Venetia in 1866 and in 1870 we should not have entered Rome. The years going from 1870 to 1915 cover a period which marked, even in the opinion of the high priests of the new creed, the twilight of their religion, attacked by decadentism in literature and by activism in practice. Activism: that is to say nationalism, futurism, fascism.

The liberal century, after piling up innumerable Gordian Knots, tried to cut them with the sword of the world war. Never has any religion claimed so cruel a sacrifice. Were the Gods of liberalism thirsting for blood?

Now liberalism is preparing to close the doors of its temples, deserted by the peoples who feel that the agnosticism it professed in the sphere of economics and the indifferentism of which it has given proof in the sphere of politics and morals, would lead the world to ruin in the future as they have done in the past.

This explains why all the political experiments of our day are anti-liberal, and it is supremely ridiculous to endeavor on this account to put them outside the pale of history, as though history were a preserve set aside for liberalism and its adepts; as though liberalism were the last word in civilization beyond which no one can go.

The Fascist negation of socialism, democracy, liberalism, should not, however, be interpreted as implying a desire to drive the world backwards to positions occupied prior to 1789, a year commonly referred to as that which opened the demo-liberal century. History does not travel backwards. The Fascist doctrine has not taken De Maistre as its prophet. Monarchical absolutism is of the past, and so is ecclesiocracy. Dead and done for are feudal privileges and the division of society into closed, uncommunicating castes. Neither has the Fascist conception of authority anything in common with that of a police ridden State.

A party governing a nation "totalitarianly" is a new departure in history. There are no points of reference nor of comparison. From beneath the ruins of liberal, socialist, and democratic doctrines, Fascism extracts those elements which are still vital. It preserves what may be described as "the acquired facts" of history; it rejects all else. That is to say, it rejects the idea of a doctrine suited to all times and to all people. Granted that the XIXth century was the century of socialism, liberalism, democracy, this does not mean that the XXth century must also be the century of socialism, liberalism, democracy. Political doctrines pass; nations remain. We are free to believe that this is the century of authority, a century tending to the "right," a Fascist century. If the XIXth century was the century of the individual (liberalism implies individualism) we are free to believe that this is

the “collective” century, and therefore the century of the State. It is quite logical for a new doctrine to make use of the still vital elements of other doctrines. No doctrine was ever born quite new and bright and unheard of. No doctrine can boast absolute originality. It is always connected, it only historically, with those which preceded it and those which will follow it. Thus the scientific socialism of Marx links up to the utopian socialism of the Fouriers, the Owens, the Saint-Simons; thus the liberalism of the XIXth century traces its origin back to the illuministic movement of the XVIIIth, and the doctrines of democracy to those of the Encyclopaedists. All doctrines aim at directing the activities of men towards a given objective; but these activities in their turn react on the doctrine, modifying and adjusting it to new needs, or outstripping it. A doctrine must therefore be a vital act and not a verbal display. Hence the pragmatic strain in Fascism, it’s will to power, its will to live, its attitude toward violence, and its value.

The keystone of the Fascist doctrine is its conception of the State, of its essence, its functions, and its aims. For Fascism the State is absolute, individuals and groups relative. Individuals and groups are admissible in so far as they come within the State. Instead of directing the game and guiding the material and moral progress of the community, the liberal State restricts its activities to recording results. The Fascist State is wide awake and has a will of its own. For this reason it can be described as “ethical.”

At the first quinquennial assembly of the regime, in 1929, I said “The Fascist State is not a night watchman, solicitous only of the personal safety of the citizens; not is it organized exclusively for the purpose of guaranteeing a certain degree of material prosperity and relatively peaceful conditions of life, a board of directors would do as much. Neither is it exclusively political, divorced from practical realities and holding itself aloof from the multifarious activities of the citizens and the nation. The State, as conceived and realized by Fascism, is a spiritual and ethical entity for securing the political, juridical, and economic organization of the nation, an organization which in its origin and growth is a manifestation of the spirit. The State guarantees the internal and external safety of the country, but it also safeguards and transmits the spirit of the people, elaborated down the ages in its language, its customs, its faith. The State is not only the present; it is also the past and above all the future. Transcending the individual's brief spell of life, the State stands for the immanent conscience of the nation. The forms in which it finds expression change, but the need for it remains. The State educates the citizens to civism, makes them aware of their mission, urges them to unity; its justice harmonizes their divergent interests; it transmits to future generations the conquests of the mind in the fields of science, art, law, human solidarity; it leads men up from primitive tribal life to that highest manifestation of human power, imperial rule. The State hands down to future generations the memory of those who laid down their lives to ensure its safety or to obey its laws; it sets up as examples and records for future ages the names of the captains who enlarged its territory and of the men of genius who have made it famous. Whenever respect for the State declines and the disintegrating and centrifugal tendencies of individuals and groups prevail, nations are headed for decay.

Since 1929 economic and political development have everywhere emphasized these truths. The importance of the State is rapidly growing. The so-called crisis can only be settled by State action and within the orbit of the State. Where are the shades of the Jules Simons who, in the early days of liberalism proclaimed that the “State should endeavor to render itself useless and prepare to hand in its resignation”? Or of the MacCullochs who, in the second half of last century, urged that the State should desist from governing too much? And what of the

English Bentham who considered that all industry asked of government was to be left alone, and of the German Humboldt who expressed the opinion that the best government was a lazy one? What would they say now to the unceasing, inevitable, and urgently requested interventions of government in business? It is true that the second generation of economists was less uncompromising in this respect than the first, and that even Adam Smith left the door ajar—however cautiously—for government intervention in business.

If liberalism spells individualism, Fascism spells government. The Fascist State is, however, a unique and original creation. It is not reactionary but revolutionary, for it anticipates the solution of certain universal problems which have been raised elsewhere, in the political field by the splitting up of parties, the usurpation of power by parliaments, the irresponsibility of assemblies; in the economic field by the increasingly numerous and important functions discharged by trade unions and trade associations with their disputes and ententes, affecting both capital and labor; in the ethical field by the need felt for order, discipline, obedience to the moral dictates of patriotism.

Fascism desires the State to be strong and organic, based on broad foundations of popular support. The Fascist State lays claim to rule in the economic field no less than in others; it makes its action felt throughout the length and breadth of the country by means of its corporative, social, and educational institutions, and all the political, economic, and spiritual forces of the nation, organized in their respective associations, circulate within the State. A State based on millions of individuals who recognize its authority, feel its action, and are ready to serve its ends is not the tyrannical state of a mediaeval lordling. It has nothing in common with the despotic States existing prior to or subsequent to 1789. Far from crushing the individual, the Fascist State multiplies his energies, just as in a regiment a soldier is not diminished but multiplied by the number of his fellow soldiers.

The Fascist State organizes the nation, but it leaves the individual adequate elbow room. It has curtailed useless or harmful liberties while preserving those which are essential. In such matters the individual cannot be the judge, but the State only.

The Fascist State is not indifferent to religious phenomena in general nor does it maintain an attitude of indifference to Roman Catholicism, the special, positive religion of Italians. The State has not got a theology but it has a moral code. The Fascist State sees in religion one of the deepest of spiritual manifestations and for this reason it not only respects religion but defends and protects it. The Fascist State does not attempt, as did Robespierre at the height of the revolutionary delirium of the Convention, to set up a “god” of its own; nor does it vainly seek, as does Bolshevism, to efface God from the soul of man. Fascism respects the God of ascetics, saints, and heroes, and it also respects God as conceived by the ingenuous and primitive heart of the people, the God to whom their prayers are raised.

The Fascist State expresses the will to exercise power and to command. Here the Roman tradition is embodied in a conception of strength. Imperial power, as understood by the Fascist doctrine, is not only territorial, or military, or commercial; it is also spiritual and ethical. An imperial nation, that is to say a nation which directly or indirectly is a leader of others, can exist without the need of conquering a single square mile of territory. Fascism sees in the imperialistic spirit—i.e. in the tendency of nations to expand—a manifestation of their vitality. In the opposite tendency, which would limit their interests to the home country, it

sees a symptom of decadence. Peoples who rise or re-arise are imperialistic; renunciation is characteristic of dying peoples. The Fascist doctrine is that best suited to the tendencies and feelings of a people which, like the Italian, after lying fallow during centuries of foreign servitude, are now reasserting itself in the world.

But imperialism implies discipline, the coordination of efforts, a deep sense of duty and a spirit of self-sacrifice. This explains many aspects of the practical activity of the regime, and the direction taken by many of the forces of the State, as also the severity which has to be exercised towards those who would oppose this spontaneous and inevitable movement of XXth century Italy by agitating outgrown ideologies of the XIXth century, ideologies rejected wherever great experiments in political and social transformations are being dared.

Never before have the peoples thirsted for authority, direction, order, as they do now. If each age has its doctrine, then innumerable symptoms indicate that the doctrine of our age is the Fascist. That it is vital is shown by the fact that it has aroused a faith; that this faith has conquered souls is shown by the fact that Fascism can point to its fallen heroes and its martyrs.

Fascism has now acquired throughout the world that universality which belongs to all doctrines which by achieving self-expression represent a moment in the history of human thought.

APPENDIX

1. Philosophic conception

(1) If Fascism does not wish to die or, worse still, commit suicide, it must now provide itself with a doctrine. Yet this shall not and must not be a robe of Nessus clinging to us for all eternity, for tomorrow is some thing mysterious and unforeseen. This doctrine shall be a norm to guide political and individual action in our daily life.

I who have I dictated this doctrine, am the first to realize that the modest tables of our laws and program the theoretical and practical guidance of Fascism should be revised, corrected, enlarged, developed, because already in parts they have suffered injury at the hand of time. I believe the essence and fundamentals of the doctrine are still to be found in the postulates which throughout two years have acted as a call to arms for the recruits of Italian Fascism. However, in taking those first fundamental assumptions for a starting point, we must proceed to carry our program into a vaster field.

Italian Fascists, one and all, should cooperate in this task, one of vital importance to Fascism, and more especially those who belong to regions where with and without agreement peaceful coexistence has been achieved between two antagonistic movements.

The word I am about to use is a great one, but indeed I do wish that during the two months which are still to elapse before our National Assembly meets, the philosophy of Fascism could be created. Milan is already contributing with the first Fascist school of propaganda.

It is not merely a question of gathering elements for a program, to be used as a solid foundation for the constitution of a party which must inevitably arise from the Fascist movement; it is also a question of denying the silly tale that Fascism is all made up of violent men. In point of fact among Fascists there are many men who belong to the restless but meditative class.

The new course taken by Fascist activity will in no way diminish the fighting spirit typical of Fascism. To furnish the mind with doctrines and creeds does not mean to disarm, rather it signifies to strength-en our power of action, and make us ever more conscious of our work. Soldiers who fight fully conscious of the cause make the best of warriors. Fascism takes for its own the twofold device of Mazzini: Thought and Action. (Letter to Michele Bianchi, written on August 27, 1921, for the opening of the School of Fascist Culture and Propaganda in Milan, in *Messaggi e Proclami*, Milano, Libreria d'Italia, 1929, P. 39).

Fascists must be placed in contact with one another; their activity must be an activity of doctrine, an activity of the spirit and of thought

Had our adversaries been present at our meeting, they would have been convinced that Fascism is not only action, but thought as well (Speech before the National Council of the Fascist Party, August 8, 1924, in *La Nuova Politica dell'Italia*, Milano, Alpes, 1928, p. 267).

(2) Today I hold that Fascism as an idea, a doctrine, a realization, is universal; it is Italian in its particular institutions, but it is universal in the spirit, nor could it be otherwise. The spirit is universal by reason of its nature. Therefore anyone may foresee a Fascist Europe. Drawing inspiration for her institutions from the doctrine and practice of Fascism; Europe, in other words, giving a Fascist turn to

the solution of problems which beset the modern State, the Twentieth Century State which is very different from the States existing before 1789, and the States formed immediately after. Today Fascism fills universal requirements; Fascism solves the threefold problem of relations between State and individual, between State and associations, between associations and organized associations. (Message for the year 1 October 27, 1930, in *Discorsi del 1930*, Milano, Alpes, 1931, p. 211).

2. Spiritualized conception

(3) This political process is flanked by a philosophic process. If it be true that matter was on the altars for one century, today it is the spirit which takes its place. All manifestations peculiar to the democratic spirit are consequently repudiated: easygoingness, improvisation, the lack of a personal sense of responsibility, the exaltation of numbers and of that mysterious divinity called 'The People'. All creations of the spirit starting with that religious are coming to the fore, and nobody dare keep up the attitude of anticlericalism which, for several decades, was a favorite with Democracy in the Western world. By saying that God is returning, we mean that spiritual values are returning. (Da the parte va it mondo, in *Tempi della Rivoluzione Fascista*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 34).

There is a field reserved more to meditation upon the supreme ends of life than to a research of these ends. Consequently science starts from experience, but breaks out fatally into philosophy and, in my opinion, philosophy alone can enlighten science and lead to the universal idea. (To the Congress of Science at Bologna, October 31, 1926, in *Discorsi del 1926*. Milano, Alpes, 1927, p. 268).

In order to understand the Fascist movement one must first appreciate the underlying spiritual phenomenon in all its vastness and depth. The manifestations of the movement have been of a powerful and decisive nature, but one should go further. In point of fact Italian Fascism has not only been a political revolt against weak and incapable governments who had allowed State authority to decay and were threatening to arrest the progress of the country, but also a spiritual revolt against old ideas which had corrupted the sacred principles of religion, of faith, of country. Fascism, therefore, has been a revolt of the people. (Message to the British people; January 5, 1924, in *Messaggi e Proclami*, Milano, Libreria d' Italia, 1929, p. 107).

3. Positive conception of life as a struggle

(4) Struggle is at the origin of all things, for life is full of contrasts: there is love and hatred, white and black, day and night, good and evil; and until these contrasts achieve balance, struggle fatefully remains at the root of human nature. However, it is good for it to be so. Today we can indulge in wars, economic battles, conflicts of ideas, but if a day came to pass when struggle ceased to exist, that day would be tinged with melancholy; it would be a day of ruin, the day of ending. But that day will not come, because history ever discloses new horizons. By attempting to restore calm, peace, tranquility, one would be fighting the tendencies of the present period of dynamism. One must be prepared for other struggles and for other surprises. Peace will only come when people surrender to a Christian dream of universal brotherhood, when they can hold out hands across the ocean and over the mountains. Personally I do not believe very much in these idealisms, but I do not exclude them for I exclude nothing. (At the Politeama

Rossetti, Trieste , September 20, 1920 ; in *Discorsi Politici*, Milano, Stab. Tipografico del Popolo d' Italia, 1921, p. 107).

(5) For me the honor of nations consists in the contribution they have severally made to human civilization. (E. Ludwig, *Talks with Mussolini*, London, Allen and Unwin, 1932, p. 199).

4. Ethical conception

I called the organization Fasci Italiani Di combat tin onto. This hard metallic name compromised the whole program of Fascism as I dreamed it. Comrades, this is still our program: fight.

Life for the Fascist is a continuous, ceaseless fight, which we accept with ease, with great courage, with the necessary intrepidity. (On the VIIth anniversary of the Foundation of the Fasci, March 2E, 1926, in *Discorsi del 1926*, Milano, Alpes, 1927, P. 98).

You touch the core of Fascist philosophy. When recently a Finnish philosopher asked me to expound to him the significance of Fascism in one sentence, I wrote in German: We are against the "easy life." (E. Ludwig: Talks with Mussolini, London, Allen and Unwin, 1932, p. 190.)

5. Religious conception

(7) If Fascism were not a creed how could it endow its followers with courage and stoicism only a creed which has soared to the heights of religion can inspire such words as passed the lips, now lifeless alas, of Federico Florio. (Legami di Sangue, in *Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 256).

6. Historical and realistic conception

(8) Tradition certainly is one of the greatest spiritual forces of a people, inasmuch as it is a successive and constant creation of their soul. (Breve Preludio, in *Tempi della Rivoluzione Fascista*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p.13).

(9) Our temperament leads us to appraise the concrete aspect of problems, rather than their ideological or mystical sublimation. There-fore we easily regain our balance. (Aspetti del Dramma, in *Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 86).

Our battle is an ungrateful one, yet it is a beautiful battle since it compels us to count only upon our own forces. Revealed truths we have torn to shreds, dogmas we have spat upon, we have rejected all theories of paradise, we have baffled charlatans white, red, black charlatans who placed miraculous drugs on the market to give a happiness n to mankind. We do not believe in program, in plans, in saints or apostles, above all we believe not in happiness, in salvation, in the Promised Land. (*Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 223).

We do not believe in a single solution, be it economical, political or moral, a linear solution of the problems of life, because of illustrious choristers from all the sacristies life is not linear and can never be reduced to a segment traced by primordial needs. (Navigare necesse, in *Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 233).

(10) We are not and do not wish to be motionless mummies, with faces perpetually turned towards the same horizon, nor do we wish to shut ourselves up within the narrow hedges of subversive bigotry, where formulas, like prayers

of a professed religion, are muttered mechanically. We are men, living men, who wish to give our contribution, however modest, to the creation of history. (Audacia, in *Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 1.)

We uphold moral and traditional values which Socialism neglects or despises; but, above all, Fascism has a horror of anything implying an arbitrary mortgage on the mysterious future. (Dopo due anni, in *Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 242).

In spite of the theories of conservation and renovation, of tradition and progress expounded by the right and the left, we do not cling desperately to the past as to a last board of salvation: yet we do not dash headlong into the seductive mists of the future. (Breve preludio, in *Diuturna*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 14). Negation, eternal immobility, mean damnation. I am all for motion. I am, one who marches on. (E. Ludwig, *Talks with Mussolini*, Lot Jon, Allen and Unwin, 1932, p. 203).

7. The individual and liberty

(11) We were the first to state, in the face of demo liberal individualism, that the individual exists only in so far as he is within the State and subjected to the requirements of the state and that, as civilization assumes aspects which grow more and more complicated, individual freedom becomes more and more restricted. (To the General Staff Conference of Fascism, in *Discorsi del 1929*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 280).

The sense of the state grows within the consciousness of Italians, for they feel that the state alone is the irreplaceable safeguard of their unit and independence; that the state alone represents continuity into the future of their stock and their history. (Message on the VIIth anniversary, October 25, 1929, *Discorsi del 1929*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 300).

If, in the course of the past eight years, we have made such astounding progress, you may well think suppose and foresee that in the course of the next fifty or eighty years the onward trend of Italy, of this Italy we feel to be so powerful, so full of vital fluid, will really be grandiose. It will be so especially if concord lasts among citizens, if the State continues to be sole arbitrator in political and social conflicts, if all remains within the state and nothing outside the State, because it is impossible to conceive any individual existing outside the State unless he be a savage whose home is in the solitude of the sandy desert. (Speech before the Senate, May 12, 1928, in *Discorsi del 1928*, Milano, Alpes, 1929, p. 109).

Fascism has restored to the State its sovereign functions by claiming its absolute ethical meaning, against the egotism of classes and categories; to the Government of the state, which was reduced to a mere instrument of electoral assemblies, it has restored dignity, as representing the personality of the state and its power of Empire. It has rescued State administration from the weight of factions and party interests (To the council of state, December 22, 1928, in *Discorsi Del 1928*, Milano, Alpes, 1929 p.328).

(12) Let no one think of denying the moral character of Fascism. For I should be ashamed to speak from this tribune if I did not feel that I represent the moral and spiritual powers of the state. What would the state be if it did not possess a spirit of its own, and a morality of its own, which lend power to the laws in virtue of which the state is obeyed by its citizens?

The Fascist state claims its ethical character: it is Catholic but above all it is Fascist, in fact it is exclusively and essentially Fascist. Catholicism completes

Fascism, and this we openly declare, but let no one think they can turn the tables on us, under cover of metaphysics or philosophy. (To the Chamber of Deputies, May 13, 1929, in *Discorsi del 1929*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 182).

A State which is fully aware of its mission and represents a people which are marching on; a state which necessarily transforms the people even in their physical aspect. In order to be something more than a mere administrator, the State must utter great words, expound great ideas and place great problems before this people (*Discorsi del 1929*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 183).

(13) The concept of freedom is not absolute because nothing is ever absolute in life. Freedom is not a right, it is a duty. It is not a gift, it is a conquest; it is not equality, it is a privilege. The concept of freedom changes with the passing of time. There is a freedom in times of peace which is not the freedom of times of war. There is a freedom in times of prosperity which is not a freedom to be allowed in times of poverty. (Fifth anniversary of the foundation of the Fasci di Combattimento, March 24, 1924, in *La nuova politica dell'Italia*, vol. III, Milano, Alpes, 1925, p. 30).

In our state the individual is not deprived of freedom. In fact, he has greater liberty than an isolated man, because the state protects him and he is part of the State. Isolated man is without defence. (E. Ludwig, *Talks with Mussolini*, London, Allen and Unwin, 1932, P. 129).

(14) Today we may tell the world of the creation of the powerful united State of Italy, ranging from the Alps to Sicily; this State is expressed by a well-organized, centralized, Unitarian democracy, where people circulate at ease. Indeed, gentlemen, you admit the people into the citadel of the State and the people will defend it, if you close them out, the people will assault it. (speech before the Chamber of Deputies, May 26, 1927, in *Discorsi del 1927*, Milano, Alpes, 1928, p. 159).

In the Fascist regime the unity of classes, the political, social and moral unity of the Italian people is realized within the state, and only within the Fascist state. (speech before the Chamber of Deputies, December 9, 1928, in *Discorsi del 1928*, Milano, Alpes, 1929, p. 333).

8. Conception of a corporative state

(15) We have created the united state of Italy remember that since the Empire Italy had not been a united state. Here I wish to reaffirm solemnly our doctrine of the State. Here I wish to reaffirm with no weaker energy, the formula I expounded at the scala in Milan everything in the state, nothing against the State, nothing outside the state. (Speech before the Chamber of Deputies, May 26, 1927, *Discorsi del 1927*, Milano, Alpes, 1928, p. 157).

(16) We are, in other words, a state which controls all forces acting in nature. We control political forces, we control moral forces we control economic forces, therefore we are a full-blown Corporative state. We stand for a new principle in the world, we stand for sheer, categorical, definitive antithesis to the world of democracy, plutocracy, free-masonry, to the world which still abides by the fundamental principles laid down in 1789. (Speech before the new National Directory of the Party, April 7, 1926, in *Discorsi del 1926*, Milano, Alpes, 1927, p. 120).

The Ministry of Corporations is not a bureaucratic organ, nor does it wish to exercise the functions of syndical organizations which are necessarily independent, since they aim at organizing, selecting and improving the members of syndicates. The Ministry of Corporations is an institution in virtue of which, in the centre and outside, integral corporation becomes an accomplished fact, where balance is achieved between interests and forces of the economic world. Such a glance is only possible within the sphere of the state, because the state alone transcends the contrasting interests of groups and individuals, in view of co-ordinating them to achieve higher aims. The achievement of these aims is speeded up by the fact that all economic organizations, acknowledged, safeguarded and supported by the Corporative State, exist within the orbit of Fascism; in other terms they accept the conception of Fascism in theory and in practice. (speech at the opening of the Ministry of Corporations, July 31, 1926, in *Discorsi del 1926*, Milano, Alpes, 1927, p. 250).

We have constituted a Corporative and Fascist state, the state of national society, a State which concentrates, controls, harmonizes and tempers the interests of all social classes, which are thereby protected in equal measure. Whereas, during the years of demo-liberal regime, labour looked with diffidence upon the state, was, in fact, outside the State and against the state, and considered the state an enemy of every day and every hour, there is not one working Italian today who does not seek a place in his Corporation or federation, who does not wish to be a living atom of that great, immense, living organization which is the national Corporate State of Fascism. (On the Fourth Anniversary of the March on Rome, October 28, 1926, in *Discorsi del 1926*, Milano, Alpes, 1927, p. 340).

9. Democracy

(17) The war was revolutionary, in the sense that with streams of blood it did away with the century of Democracy, the century of number, the century of majorities and of quantities. (Da the pane va it Mondo, in *Tempi della Rivoluzione Fascista*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 37).

(18) Cf. note 13.

(19) Race: it is a feeling and not a reality; 95% a feeling. (E. Ludwig, *Talks with Mussolini*, London, Allen and Unwin, 1932, p. 75).

10. Conception of the state

(20) A nation exists inasmuch as it is a people. A people rise inasmuch as they are numerous, hard working and well regulated. Power is the outcome of this threefold principle. (To the General Assembly of the Party, March 10, 1929, in *Discorsi del 1929*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 24).

Fascism does not deny the State; Fascism maintains that a civic society, national or imperial, cannot be conceived unless in the form of a State (Stab, anti-Slato, Fascismo, in *Tempi della Rivoluzione Fascista*, Milano, Alpes, 1930, p. 94). For us the Nation is mainly spirit and not only territory. There are States which owned immense territories and yet left no trace in the history of mankind. Neither is it a question of number, because there have been, in history, small, microscopic States, which left immortal, imperishable documents in art and philosophy.

The greatness of a nation is the compound of all these virtues and conditions. A nation is great when the power of the spirit is translated into reality. (Speech at

Naples, October 24, 1922, in *Discorsi della Rivoluzione*, Milano, Alpes, 1928, p. 103). We wish to unity the nation within the sovereign State, which is above everyone and can afford to be against everyone, since it represents the moral continuity of the nation in history. Without the State there is no nation. There are merely human aggregations subject to all the disintegrations which history may inflict upon them. (Speech before the National Council of the Fascist Party, August 8, 1924, in *La Nuova Politica dell'Italia*, vol. III; Milano, Alpes, 1928, p. 269).

11. Dynamic reality

(21) I believe that if a people wish to live they should develop a will to power, otherwise they vegetate, live miserably and become prey to a stronger people, in whom this will to power is developed to a higher degree. (Speech to the Senate, May 28, 1926).

(22) It is Fascism which has refashioned the character of the Italians, removing impurity from our souls, tempering us to all sacrifices, restoring the true aspect of strength and beauty to our Italian face. (Speech delivered at Pisa, May 25, 1926, in *Discorsi del 1926*, Milano, Alpes, 1927, p. 193).

It is not out of place to illustrate the intrinsic character and profound significance of the Fascist Levy. It is not merely a ceremony, but a very important stage in the system of education and integral preparation of Italian men which the Fascist revolution considers one of the fundamental duties of the State: fundamental indeed, for if the State does not fulfill this duty or in any way accepts to place it under discussion, the State merely and simply forfeits its right to exist. (Speech before the Chamber of Deputies, May 28, 1928, in *Discorsi del 1928*, Milano, Alpes, 1929, p. 68).

* * *

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EDITORE - ULRICO HOEPLI - MILANO

1939-XVII

P R E M E S S A

Questa Dottrina del Fascismo appare nell'anno XVII dell'Era Fascista, nel corso del quale si celebra insieme il ventennale della Vittoria nella Grande Guerra e il ventennale della fondazione dei Fasci di Combattimento; ed appare quando i precetti della nostra dottrina politica e l'opera del Duce si sono proiettati e hanno esercitato la loro decisiva influenza su tutta l'Europa.

Ma questo libro appare quando la riforma costituzionale, iniziata dal Governo fascista nel 1923 colla costituzione del Gran Consiglio del Fascismo e sviluppata ininterrottamente colla promulgazione e coll'applicazione delle altre leggi fondamentali, si perfeziona ora colla istituzione della Camera dei Fasci e delle Corporazioni; ed appare quando il Governo prepara il riordinamento dell'educazione delle generazioni nuove, conforme ai principii e alle direttive contenuti nella « Carta della Scuola ».

Così l'esposizione della nostra dottrina si completa con tutto quanto ha attinenza alla recentissima legislazione.

La presente trattazione, che segue l'ordine e l'insegnamento della Dottrina del Fascismo dettata dal Duce (le citazioni di detta Dottrina sono riportate in corsivo nel testo o a piede di pagina), presenta carattere ad un

tempo scientifico e pratico, discostandosi, per quanto è possibile, dagli schemi elementari ed assumendo inizialmente i principii, per illustrarli a traverso l'ordine morale e sociale, il sistema corporativo, l'ordinamento giuridico e la riforma costituzionale. Non vengono particolarmente commentati i singoli istituti, per dare solo la nozione della loro origine, della loro costituzione, dei loro scopi e dei loro caratteri, pienamente aderenti allo spirito della rivoluzione ricostruttiva.

Questo Manuale segue e completa l'altro precedente sulla Storia del Fascismo; e con esso costituisce il piano, sul quale poggiano e si sviluppano le trattazioni degli altri volumi della mia collezione su L'ordinamento corporativo.

G. B.

Roma, marzo 1939-XVII.

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per il vario e per il pittoresco, per l'attività personale, con netta avversione e ritrosia per l'uniformità e per la regolamentazione.

Il popolo italiano ebbe in passato, specialmente nelle classi meno elevate, scarsi doni di cultura; ma ebbe sempre, in tutte le classi, anche nelle più modeste, ricchissime doti di intelligenza, di destrezza, di ingegnosità, d'iniziativa. Queste sue doti permisero sovente agli italiani di affermarsi e di elevarsi sia nel campo delle conquiste, sia nei ranghi della vita sociale, sia nella situazione economica.

Non aveva il popolo italiano nè le attitudini, nè l'educazione tradizionale per assumere e seguire la disciplina e l'organizzazione militare, pur possedendo la bravura e il coraggio personale ⁽¹⁾. Ma è bastato che l'educazione civile si rivolgesse al patrimonio d'intelligenza, di coraggio e di prontezza del popolo italiano, perchè egli desse subito la misura della sua attitudine all'obbedienza, alla disciplina e al servizio delle armi ⁽²⁾.

Con questo l'italiano del tempo di Mussolini appare ad un tempo eguale e diverso da quello, che la tradizione ha creato; uguale, perchè tutte le sue doti e tutti i difetti tradizionali sono rimasti; diverso, perchè sopra queste sue doti caratteristiche sono venute costituendosi le realtà della rivoluzione ricostruttiva, e le influenze della disciplina nazionale. E si sono rafforzate e composte tutte le virtù ataviche della nostra gente, che assunse la volontà di esistenza e di conquista e perfezionò la propria personalità, la propria coscienza e il proprio carattere ⁽³⁾.

61. La morale fascista «è forma e norma interiore e disciplina di tutta la persona; penetra la volontà come l'in-

⁽¹⁾ BORTOLOTTO G., *Storia del fascismo*, p. 117 e segg.

⁽²⁾ Vedi VOLPE G., *L'Italia in cammino*, p. 35 e segg.

⁽³⁾ Vedi MUSSOLINI B., *Dottrina*, I, 9. Vedi più innanzi n. 204 e segg.

PARTE SECONDA

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I. - L'ORDINE SOCIALE

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70. Ogni rivoluzione ha per oggetto la trasformazione dello Stato. Ma una rivoluzione non si può dire completa, nè può raggiungere in pieno i suoi scopi, se non presenta, oltre a quello morale e politico, anche il suo dato sociale. Il dato sociale è raggiunto, quando la rivoluzione,

DOTTRINA (*). — A) *Dottrina sociale.* — AMORTH A., *La nozione di gerarchia*, Milano, 1936; ANDREANI F., *Saggi critici sulla legislazione sociale in Italia*, Roma, 1920; ANDREOLI G., *Le gerarchie e lo Stato*, « *L'economia italiana* », 1929, n. 4, p. 91; ARENA C., *La politica sociale*, Roma, VI; BALLERINI G. V., *La rappresentanza politica degli ordini sociali*, Torino, 1897; BALZARINI R., *Società e Stato*, Roma, 1933. « Il diritto del lavoro », an. VII, p. 270; BIAGI B., *Politica sociale del fascismo*, « *Gerarchia* », an. XII, 1932, p. 1024; BORTOLOTTO G., *Le masse e lo Stato in regime corporativo*, Roma, 1932;

(*) Per più ampia rassegna di dottrina veggasi il volume di questa collezione che tratta particolarmente la materia: BORTOLOTTO G., *Politica e legislazione sociale*, Milano, 1936.

dopo aver operato sugli spiriti e sulle coscienze (dato morale) e sugli ordinamenti (dato politico) si rivolge alla realtà materiale e pratica della vita organizzata, assume in considerazione gli interessi vari, e talora con-

Id., *Governanti e governati del nostro tempo*, Milano, 1933; Id., *Il dato sociale della rivoluzione*, « Rinnovamento », aprile 1935; Id., *Politica e legislazione sociale*, Milano, 1936; BUFFA A., *Politica sociale*, « Economia italiana », novembre-dicembre 1934; CALESINI A., *La legislazione sociale*, Roma, 1914; CAPALLOZZA C., *Compendio di legislazione sociale*, Milano, 1935; CARLI F., *Saggi di storia economica sociale*, Pisa 1932; Id., *Introduzione alla sociologia*, Bologna, 1926; CASTELLI E., *Individuo e Stato*, « Arch. di filos. », settembre 1932; CAVAZZONI S., *La difesa della famiglia*, « Il Libro d'Italia », Milano, 1929, p. 75; CHIARELLI G., *Il concetto di regime nel diritto pubblico*, « Arch. giuridico », 1932; Id., *Individuo e Stato*, Roma, 1927; COLETTI F., *L'unità e la fusione solidale degli italiani*, « Corriere della Sera », 31 dicembre 1932; CURCIO C., *Un corporativista di trent'anni fa*, « Lo Stato », settembre 1930; D'ANDREA U., *Compiti di una nuova borghesia*, « Il Giornale d'Italia », 26 gennaio 1934; DEL GIUDICE R., *Lo Stato fascista e la questione sociale*, « Rivista del Lavoro », 30 settembre 1937; DE SANTIS G., *Manuale di legislazione sociale*, Firenze, 1928; DE SARLO, *L'uomo nella vita sociale*, Bari, 1931; DE VALLES A., *Il concetto giuridico di gerarchia*, Como, 1926; DE VARGAS M. A., *L'aristocrazia italiana nel regime fascista*, « Il Giornale d'Italia », 11 maggio 1933; FANI CIOTTI V., *Il concetto sociologico dello Stato*, « Gerarchia », 1922, I, p. 422; FANTINI O., *Corso completo di legislazione sociale e del lavoro*, Perugia, 1930; Id., *La legislazione sociale nell'Italia corporativa e negli altri Stati*, Roma, 1931; FERRARI A. C., *La nazionalità e la vita sociale*, Palermo, 1896; FLUMIANI C., *I gruppi sociali*, Milano, 1928; FORGES DAVANZATI R., *Intelligenza, corporazione e Stato*, « La Tribuna », 2 maggio 1931; GENTILE G., *La politica sociale del regime*, « Politica sociale », novembre 1932; GIANI N., *Le tappe della politica sociale del regime*, « Popolo d'Italia », 18 aprile 1933; Id., *Lineamenti su l'ordinamento sociale dello Stato fascista*, Milano, 1934; GOMEZ HOMEN P. F., *Antecedenti storici del corporativismo fascista*,

trastanti, che in essa si esprimono, e tende al raggiungimento degli scopi dei singoli, delle collettività sociali e dello Stato, conforme agli spiriti e ai principii, che animano e sospingono il movimento rivoluzionario. Solo

Palermo, 1929; GROPPALI A., *Elementi di sociologia*, Genova, 1905; INCISA L., *La questione sociale e il corporativismo*, Torino, 1932; JAEGER N., *La nuova società nazionale e lo Stato corporativo*, in « Funzione imperiale della scuola », Padova, 1937-XV; LOJACONO F., *La politica sociale del fascismo*, « Gerarchia », gennaio 1935; MARAVIGLIA M., *Rivoluzioni politiche e rivoluzioni sociali*, « Il Popolo d'Italia », 30 giugno 1932; MARCHI A., *Giustizia Sociale*, Udine, 1935; MASTROSTEFANO R., *Individuo e società*, « Giornale d'Italia », 8 marzo 1935; MEZZETTI N., *Un decennio di politica sociale del regime*, Roma, 1932; MICELI V., *Stato, società, individuo*, « Critica fascista », 15 agosto 1926; MICHELS R., *Corso di sociologia politica*, Milano, 1927; MÜLLER A., *La missione sociale dello Stato*, Roma, 1924; NOARO G., *Nuovo manuale completo di legislazione sociale*, Roma, 1927; OLGATI F., *Il divenire sociale*, Milano, 1921; PANUNZIO S., *Tutta la vita*, « Il Popolo d'Italia », 27 settembre 1933; PARENTI G., *L'evoluzione quantitativa degli aggregati umani*, Firenze, 1934; PARETO V., *Il massimo di utilità per una collettività in sociologia*, « Giornale degli economisti », aprile 1913; ID., *Trattato di sociologia generale*, Firenze, 1923; PAVESE R., *Capo e folla nella storia*, « Il Popolo d'Italia », 4 maggio 1934; PERTICONE G., *Fare l'unità, ma rifare la società*, « Politica sociale », marzo-aprile 1930; PETRONE I., *Nascita della folla*, « Il Popolo d'Italia », 23 gennaio 1934; PINO BRANCA A., *La funzione sociale delle corporazioni nella storia*, Padova, 1930; RICCI R., *I giovani e la politica sociale del regime*, « Politica sociale », 1929; RUTA E., *Politica e ideologia*, Milano, 1929; SANTAMARIA N., *Politica nuova*, Firenze, 1883; SENSINI G., *Studi di scienze sociali*, Roma, 1932; SESTI L., *Il problema sociale*; SEVERINI C., *La nuova maniera sociale*, Livorno, 1927; SILIPRANDI P., *L'illusione individualista e la crisi della società europea*, Torino, 1922; SPIRITO U., *Individuo e Stato nella concezione corporativa*, « Atti » del II Convegno di studi sindacali e corpor., Ferrara, 1932; SULIS E., *Aristocrazia e comando*, « Il Resto

in questo momento la rivoluzione, diventando sociale, assume la sua vera funzione ricostruttiva, affermandosi nel suo stabile assetto realizzatore. Soltanto in tal guisa una rivoluzione può segnare un'impronta profonda nella storia e nella vita d'un popolo, portando un nuovo assetto sociale, una nuova distribuzione e una nuova gerarchia di valori in tutte le categorie della società organizzata ⁽¹⁾.

La rivoluzione fascista si differenzia, per il suo dato sociale, da tutte le altre rivoluzioni. La rivoluzione francese, democratica, presenta un dato sociale borghese, individualista, areligioso; la rivoluzione russa, bolscevica, presenta un dato sociale comunista, materialista, anti-religioso; la rivoluzione italiana, fascista, presenta un dato sociale nazionale, corporativo, etico e religioso ⁽²⁾.

Il dato sociale della rivoluzione fascista è il corporativismo, che realizza la disciplina dell'esistenza organizzata in base all'eguaglianza di tutti gli individui dinanzi alla legge e al lavoro. Esso disciplina la collaborazione di tutte le classi e di tutte le categorie sociali per il con-

del Carlino, 26 dicembre 1934; TEDESCHI N., *Manuale sintetico di legislazione sociale*, Milano, 1924; TOMBESI U., *La Carta del lavoro e la legislazione sociale*, Urbino 1928; VALLINI A., *La legislazione fascista*, Milano, 1928; VOLPE G., *Fra storia e politica*, Roma, 1924.

(¹) MUSSOLINI B., Discorso tenuto il 14 novembre innanzi al Consiglio nazionale delle Corporazioni. Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Politica corporativa*, Milano, 1937, p. 144 e segg.

(²) Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Politica e legislazione sociale*, Milano 1936, p. 2 seg.; BORTOLOTTO G., *Il dato sociale della rivoluzione fascista*, « Rinascimento », aprile 1935. Noi distinguiamo, in questa nostra trattazione, per ordine e simmetria di esposizione, il dato sociale vero e proprio dal dato economico. Il dato sociale propriamente detto riguarda lo studio del complesso dei valori sociali e il contributo che la materia sociologica conferisce alla nostra dottrina. Il dato propriamente detto economico riguarda il complesso dei valori attinenti all'economia e il contributo che alla nostra dottrina conferisce la materia economica relativa alle energie produttive.

seguimento del benessere dei singoli e per lo sviluppo della potenza della nazione e cura la protezione, l'assistenza e la tutela di tutte le energie e di tutti i valori sul piano della solidarietà nazionale.

« Il corporativismo si pone, come principio essenziale dell'organizzazione dello Stato, tra l'individualismo e il collettivismo, con una vitalità e con una precisione, che li superano e li sostituiscono, per l'aderenza alle esigenze sociali della vita dello Stato. È il principio della civiltà nuova, che impronta di sè integralmente lo Stato ⁽¹⁾. Fra il collettivismo, che annienta l'individuo, e l'individualismo egoistico ed arbitrario, che indebolisce e compromette l'autorità dello Stato, la dottrina corporativa risolve il problema dei rapporti dell'individuo collo Stato in forma giusta, equilibrata e soprattutto rispondente alla realtà della vita e alle esigenze sociali.

71. a) Secondo la *dottrina individualistica*: l'individuo è il soggetto principale, anzi è l'unica realtà della vita organizzata; l'*aggregato* è soltanto una somma di individui, una pluralità atomistica, senza unità nè valore soggettivo; la *società* è contrapposta allo Stato; lo Stato viene concepito come Stato di diritto, esistente per la pura garanzia degli individui e sfornito di ogni autorità; il *diritto* appare come la difesa delle prerogative e degli interessi individuali e come il regolamento delle relazioni tra i soggetti singoli; i *rapporti giuridici* sono i rapporti, dove campeggia, in piena preminenza, come soggetto principale, l'individuo; la *dottrina politica* è la dottrina dello Stato demoliberale.

b) Secondo la *dottrina collettivistica*: l'individuo non esiste e scompare nell'aggregato o nell'organismo, che

(1) BOTTAI G., in « Diritto del Lavoro », dicembre 1937. Vedi anche BORTOLOTTO G., *Lo stato e la dottrina corporativa*, Bologna, 1931, vol. I, p. 87 e segg.; ID., *Politica corporativa*, Milano, 1937, p. 36 e segg.

è la vera unità iniziale la *società* ed è prevalente ed assorbente; lo *Stato* rappresenta la supremazia senza limiti e si afferma come un'autorità collettivistica, e come un corpo biologicamente funzionante, al quale tutti sono necessariamente legati; il *diritto* è pura forza e garanzia del corpo sociale; i *rapporti giuridici* sono rapporti di piena supremazia della società e di piena sottomissione dell'individuo; la *dottrina politica* è quella dello Stato dominante.

Secondo la *dottrina corporativa*: l'individuo è un'entità necessaria della vita sociale, ma esso non rappresenta la sola unità soggettiva; l'*aggregato* è pure considerato come un'entità unitaria, fornita di personalità e di capacità giuridica, la quale tuttavia non abolisce le unità, le personalità e le capacità individuali; la *società* è, nell'espressione sociologica, quello che lo Stato è nell'espressione giuridica; ed è tolta l'antitesi fra la società e lo Stato; lo Stato è persona giuridica sovrana, che esprime una propria volontà e fa valere un proprio interesse, ammettendo e tutelando, nel contempo, gli interessi dei singoli e delle collettività; il *diritto* è la garanzia degli interessi di tutti, che debbono essere subordinati all'interesse superiore dello Stato; i *rapporti giuridici* presentano carattere gerarchico e corporativo; la *dottrina politica* è quella dello Stato fascista unitario sovrano, autoritario, totalitario e corporativo ⁽¹⁾.

La concezione organica della vita, che costituisce la base della dottrina del fascismo e che si fonda sull'armonia, sulla solidarietà e sulla collaborazione, porta a fissare l'essenza e il concetto ideale della corporazione come principio informatore e come direttiva funzionale dell'esistenza organizzata. Per conseguenza il principio corporativo si può definire la determinazione ed il col-

(1) Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Politica corporativa*, Milano, 1937, p. 67, 68; ID., *Lo Stato e la dottrina corporativa*, Bologna, 1931, v. I, p. 174 e segg.

locamento dei valori nel sistema unitario ed organico, allo scopo di raggiungere i maggiori conseguimenti nel campo morale, economico e politico ⁽¹⁾.

Il corporativismo, prima ancora di essere la disciplina degli organi e l'ordinamento degli enti e delle energie produttive, è un principio informatore di tutta la vita organizzata, secondo la legge, che intende all'armonia delle forze e al coordinamento della volontà ⁽²⁾.

72. Così al principio corporativo si ricongiungono altri principii fondamentali, che stanno a base della nostra dottrina; la *moralità*, che riunisce e compone tutte le manifestazioni della vita comune; l'*organizzazione*, che ricongiunge la società allo Stato e riconduce allo Stato le masse; l'*autorità*, che rende lo Stato sovrano, forte e capace di agire per il conseguimento di quegli interessi superiori, ai quali debbono essere subordinati gli interessi individuali e particolari.

In tal guisa si realizza l'unità sistematica, organica e totalitaria, che è propria dell'ordine corporativo fascista. In regime di autocrazia, l'organicità o l'organizzazione, non è concepita se non come disciplina e sottomissione piena agli ordini del capo assoluto o del dittatore o degli autocrati. In regime di liberalismo e di democrazia, il principio dell'organicità, o l'idea dell'organizzazione, esula completamente dall'ordine costituito perchè essa sembra contraddire colla concezione individualistica ed atomistica della vita. Nel comunismo il principio organico trova un'applicazione empirica, ispirata al materialismo storico ed unilaterale, vale a dire fondata sul puro predominio d'una classe. Nel nostro sistema corporativo l'applicazione del principio

(1) Vedi PANUNZIO S., *Teoria* cit., p. 124, 125.

(2) Vedi più sopra n. 10.

organico è totalitaria, coll'organizzazione interclassista e corporativa, scientifica, realistica ed umana ⁽¹⁾.

Il principio corporativo attiene pertanto all'essenza dell'ordine sociale; ma esso presuppone l'azione moralizzatrice del principio etico, che si trasferisce nella realtà attiva e funzionante del mondo e, superando l'elemento singolo, agisce sulle masse trasformandole e disciplinandole ⁽²⁾. Per questo stesso principio etico, l'organizzazione del regime fascista e corporativo non può orientarsi verso formazioni particolari e unilaterali, ma deve costituirsi in forma unitaria e generale su base nazionale e sotto la guida dello Stato. Ed allora il principio etico si adatta e si trasforma nella realtà pratica, per divenire il principio dell'ordine nel campo sociale, il principio della collaborazione e della produttività nel sistema economico, il principio dell'unità e dell'autorità nel regime politico e il principio del diritto nell'ordinamento giuridico.

Ed, in realtà, non si saprebbe concepire un'organizzazione e una gerarchia sociale in senso fascista o un sistema economico solidaristico e collaborazionistico a base corporativa, senza quel modo spiritualistico di concepire la vita, che porta alla formazione della società armonicamente organizzata e dello Stato etico, come coordinazione delle volontà e subordinazione di esse alle esigenze superiori della nazione.

Per questo le varie parti della dottrina fascista, sociale, economica e politica, che si completano l'una coll'altra e che presentano ognuna speciali settori di disciplina e di sviluppo, sono tutte riunite da questo legame spirituale, che fornisce ad un tempo il fondamento e la guida della disciplina e del regolamento unitario delle varie energie.

(1) Vedi MARCHELLO G., *Op. cit.*, p. 96.

(2) Vedi CANEPA A., *Sistema*, v. III, p. 147 e segg.

73. Occorre pertanto considerare nell'ordine sociale, alla stessa guisa che sono stati considerati nell'ordine morale, gli elementi essenziali dell'esistenza organizzata: l'individuo, le collettività e lo Stato.

Nell'ordine sociale, l'individuo è il cittadino o l'ente unitario sociale; le collettività sono rappresentate dai ceti, dalle classi, dalle categorie, dai gruppi e dagli aggregati sociali; lo Stato è la realtà sociale totalitaria ed organica, che ha per scopo l'organizzazione e la gerarchia di tutti i valori sociali, realizzando l'unità della società nazionale.

Il primo elemento sociale è l'individuo. La dottrina e il regime fascista non hanno diminuito, ma hanno elevato l'individuo, non hanno ristretto, ma hanno migliorato la sua vita, anche come semplice vita individuale; perchè hanno espresso il significato e il valore di ciascun uomo socialmente organizzato nella collettività nazionale; in questa trasformazione dell'individuo in persona sociale al servizio d'una nazione sta il contenuto universale della nostra dottrina ⁽¹⁾.

Il carattere sociale dell'etica fascista non significa negazione della personalità e dell'individuo; non significa concezione integrale della socialità e supina adorazione della collettività, ma significa riconoscimento e celebrazione dell'uomo nel momento della socialità. Infatti l'individuo diventa valore sociale in forza di questa sua tendenza, per la quale si esteriorizza e si supera, per costituirsi e svilupparsi come valore sociale e per venire a contatto cogli altri valori sociali, al fine d'integrare, in unione con essi, quell'unità sociale che è data dall'organizzazione e dalla gerarchia.

La socialità, come è intesa dalla dottrina del fascismo, fornisce la giustificazione d'un apparato sociale, nel

(1) Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Governanti e governati del nostro tempo*, Milano, 1933, p. 86 e segg.

quale non è l'interesse particolaristico dei singoli componenti il motivo, la misura e la ragione dei rapporti sociali, ma dove prevalgono l'interesse e la ragione sociale, esigendo che gli interessi individuali abbiano a uniformarsi e coordinarsi ad essi. È adunque una socialità organica e positiva e non un'astratta socialità.

Questo processo di determinazione sociale dell'individuo è la forma concreta del procedimento storico; perchè, se fuori della storia l'uomo è nulla, fuori della società l'individuo è un'astrazione; ed è assurdo pensare la costruzione e la considerazione d'un sistema di valori posti fuori della società e della storia, ovvero lontani e contro alla società e alla storia ⁽¹⁾.

74. Si dice che in ogni individuo, il quale rappresenta un elemento completo di sviluppo, esiste una forma di dualismo, per cui al suo carattere individuale si oppone una tendenza sociale. Tuttavia da questo contrasto sorge e deve sorgere una specie d'unità e d'armonia, che si considera sotto le specie dell'organizzazione. La tensione fra l'universalità dell'apparato sociale e le esigenze e le aspirazioni degli individui non si può eliminare, perchè l'una possiede la sua realtà per opera e per l'esistenza delle altre; e se una delle forze dovesse vincere, sarebbe essa stessa annientata e distrutta. Si dice che l'organizzazione della massa costituisce un apparato universale, che distrugge il mondo dell'esistenza individuale, che diventa una pura funzione di tale universale apparato ⁽²⁾. Ma noi richiamiamo i principii essenziali, per i quali il corporativismo si oppone così all'individualismo come al collettivismo, per considerare la collettività e gli individui nella loro giusta proporzione.

⁽¹⁾ Vedi MARCHELLO G., Op. cit., p. 50.

⁽²⁾ Vedi al riguardo BORTOLOTTO G., *Governanti e governati del nostro tempo*, Milano 1933, p. 51.

Si tratta di ridurre ad armonia quello che rappresentava un contrasto o una contesa; il rapporto di tensione va ridotto a rapporto di equilibrio sociale e di proporzione giuridica. L'individuo esiste e si mette in valore in quanto esso entri a far parte della massa organizzata, alla quale porta il contributo della sua ragione e della sua intelligenza; egli deve mettere il suo pensiero e la sua passione nella vita del mondo, se non vuole perdersi fuori del mondo stesso; ed il pregio della dottrina corporativa sta appunto nel comporre le collettività senza abolire gli individui, le loro volontà, le loro personalità e i loro interessi.

Va fatta pertanto una giusta distinzione, nello stesso individuo, fra soggetto isolato e soggetto sociale o socializzato. La figura del soggetto socializzato costituisce una realtà vivente dell'esistenza attuale, che si esprime per la varietà dei contatti, che l'individuo trova nella vita sociale; da questi contatti si viene gradualmente formando una solida e permanente consapevolezza, che si costituisce in coscienza.

La tendenza verso la propria personalità e la propria libertà si esprime nell'uomo come coscienza individuale; la tendenza verso la compagine sociale si esprime come coscienza collettiva. Dapprima è sentimento di adesione alla collettività; di poi è comprensione dello spirito individuale verso la formazione dell'anima collettiva; infine è determinazione e direzione delle proprie attività nell'ambiente sociale. Questa formazione psicologica si deve definire coscienza corporativa, come coscienza della comunità degli scopi e come vincolo di solidarietà e di collaborazione dell'individuo colla massa organizzata.

La coscienza corporativa è adunque il contenuto spirituale d'una collettività organizzata, come prodotto dell'umana natura, che giunge a costituire l'unità nella varietà degli elementi, che compongono la massa, facendo sorgere dalle differenze e dalle antitesi l'uniformità e

l'omogeneità. Questa coscienza è la risultante psichica di tutte le attività psichiche convergenti e interferenti tra loro. Essa non è qualche cosa di eguale alle coscienze singole; e neppure può dirsi la risultante delle coscienze singole; ma è qualche cosa di superiore e di diverso, pur avendo come presupposto le coscienze dei singoli.

Questa coscienza corporativa è costituita dall'appartenenza alla massa, dal sentimento della comunità, che è l'aspetto psicologico della massa, che non si trova affatto in contrasto coll'aspetto sociale o sociologico, ma che l'aspetto sociale completa ed integra.

75. Non è pertanto senza fondamento affermare che la tendenza sociale, che forma le masse, che le costituisce in gruppi, che le sviluppa in nazioni e che le organizza in Stati, non è altro che la tendenza iniziale dell'individuo, che, per impulso della sua natura e del suo spirito, si rivolge all'ente superiore, che rappresenta una forza e un potere, dal quale l'individuo può ottenere riconoscimento e protezione.

L'influenza, che la massa esercita su ciascuno dei suoi componenti, costituisce l'essenza dello spirito unitario, che è il fondamento della sua coesione e della sua organizzazione; e ciò è conforme alla natura e alla necessità della vita. Tutti gli interessi umani hanno la tendenza ad affermarsi, ad aprirsi una via, a mettersi in valore; la volontà, seguendo il corso degli interessi, rappresenta il costante conato verso questa affermazione, per la quale occorre tuttavia un elemento indispensabile: la forza.

Ma fattore di forza è lo Stato. Nessun gruppo sociale può affermarsi se non è sorretto e riconosciuto dallo Stato; i gruppi sociali, non ancora divenuti forze statuali, hanno la tendenza a conseguire la loro forza mediante lo Stato; e gli stessi enti e ordinamenti, che si sono venuti formando fuori della legge, talvolta in op-

posizione alla legge, non cercano affatto di aggredire lo Stato, ma, invece, per una spontanea naturale tendenza della loro attività, cercano piuttosto di avvicinarsi allo Stato, e di conformare i loro ordinamenti all'ordinamento generale⁽¹⁾. In verità, è tutto artificio quello che fa delle masse e degli aggregati sociali altrettanti enti diversi e contrari all'ordine costituito; perchè, invece, l'esperienza insegna che il movimento delle masse, in genere, non è affatto antistatuale, dal momento che tende verso l'autorità, per ottener da essa la tutela giuridica.

Così, partendo dall'individuo si giunge sino allo Stato. In omaggio ai principii morali dianzi esposti, ogni singolo e ogni formazione coltiva il proprio senso di appartenenza allo Stato. Ma questo non porta, come conseguenza, l'assorbimento nè degli individui nè delle collettività; essi invece si compongono in unità dal punto di vista sociologico e si costituiscono in personalità dal punto di vista giuridico, in seno alla suprema unità statale. Tutti gli attributi della vita sociale, vale a dire l'iniziativa, l'attività, la libertà, spettano egualmente all'individuo, agli enti sociali e allo Stato; ma lo Stato, che è sovrano, fissa e determina le sfere di attività, disciplina e vigila i comportamenti degli individui e degli aggregati e interviene solo quando l'attività degli uni o degli altri risultasse incerta o manchevole.

La dottrina corporativa toglie pertanto quella specie di antagonismo o, per dir meglio, di differenziazione esistente, in altri regimi, tra individuo e collettività e fra collettività e Stato, per comporre tutte le tendenze e le attività in solidarietà e in collaborazione per la realizzazione degli scopi comuni. La dottrina corporativa è il regolamento, fatto col mezzo dell'ordinamento giuridico, di quel così detto « meccanismo sociale », che è considerato vera e propria unione e composizione d'in-

(1) Vedi ROMANO S., *L'ordinamento giuridico*, Pisa, 1918, p. 70.

teressi, i quali, per la loro natura e la loro attuazione, non possono andare disgiunti o scomposti.

76. È questo il pregio della nostra dottrina, che si ricollega alla realtà della vita; e, mentre il demoliberalismo considera l'uomo fuori della vita del mondo (*dottrina dell'empirismo e dell'astrattismo*) e un tipo di Stato che non vive e non funziona; mentre il socialismo considera l'uomo fuori della stessa possibilità di vita (*dottrina dell'utopia*) ⁽¹⁾ e un tipo di Stato, che, vivendo e funzionando, uccide l'individuo; la dottrina del fascismo considera così l'uomo come lo Stato nella loro vivente verità (*dottrina della realtà*) funzionanti nella loro attività attuale, per modo che l'attività dell'uomo contribuisca alla potenza e al prestigio dello Stato e che l'attività dello Stato sia costantemente diretta, oltre che al conseguimento degli scopi generali, ad assicurare il benessere, il miglioramento e l'elevazione del singolo individuo e delle classi sociali.

Infatti l'uomo non è altrimenti pensabile che nella sua attività, che è quanto dire nella sua vita e nei suoi rapporti col mondo. È stato osservato che « ogni epoca storica, ogni civiltà è caratterizzata dal fatto che un motivo particolare della natura umana viene potenziato sì da divenire l'esponente di tutto un sistema ». E si pone in rilievo che, mentre nell'ellenismo il motivo dominante è dato dal senso della natura, nell'età romana dal senso del rapporto sociale, nel medioevo dal sentimento religioso, nei tempi moderni dal motivo economico, nel fascismo, pur mettendosi in primo piano il rapporto sociale e la funzione politica, viene considerato « l'uomo nella sua natura reale in tutte le sue

⁽¹⁾ Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Politica sociale del fascismo*, Milano, 1936, p. 248 e segg.

idee in tutti gli affetti, in tutti i bisogni, che ne costituiscono la vita » ⁽¹⁾.

Così il fascismo « prende tutto l'uomo, dalla culla alla morte, dal pensiero all'azione, in tutte le forme della sua pratica attività, governandolo con una immanente norma interna di vita » ⁽²⁾. E quello, che genericamente si usa designare come rapporto sociale, si fraziona e si moltiplica a seconda dei valori della vita, coi quali l'individuo entra in contatto. Infatti rapporto sociale significa l'azione reciproca, che gli individui esercitano l'uno sull'altro nel corso della vita, la quale, per il suo stesso carattere di vita umana, è il risultato di una serie infinita di rapporti.

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B) *L'individuo, la collettività e lo Stato.*

SOMMARIO. — 77. Individuo, collettività e Stato nelle moderne dottrine. — 78. Le tendenze sociali degli individui. — 79. La dottrina fascista e la concezione corporativa della vita sociale. — 80. Concezione atomistica e concezione corporativa. — 81. La società e lo Stato. — 82. Lo Stato come unità sistematica ed organica. — 83. Lo Stato e la vita.

77. Così appare la posizione corporativa dell'individuo, delle collettività e dello Stato.

Nei moderni ordinamenti sociali e politici, i rapporti si sono sempre svolti e si svolgono intorno a due termini; lo Stato da un lato, l'individuo dall'altro. Lo Stato è la potestà pubblica, l'individuo è l'attività privata; lo Stato rappresenta il principio universalistico, di fronte al singolo, che rappresenta il principio individualistico; le posizioni dell'uno rispetto all'altro si riducono sempre, in pratica, ad un'irriducibile antitesi e a un permanente

⁽¹⁾ P.N.F., *Dottrina del fascismo*, Roma, XIV, p. 71, 127.

⁽²⁾ GENTILE G., *Dopo la fondazione dell'impero*, in « L'Italia nel mondo moderno », Roma, 1936, p. 15.

conflitto. In taluni casi, lo Stato tentò e riuscì, colla sua autorità, a sottomettere al suo potere l'individuo; in altri casi, per reazione, l'individuo, colla spinta del suo personale egoismo, tentò e riuscì ad imporre la propria volontà e la prevalenza dei propri interessi individuali in confronto dello Stato.

Da un lato, lo Stato si armò di despotismo e dall'altro, per strana inversione dei termini e della logica stessa, l'attività privata ebbe a dominare la potestà pubblica nell'artificiosa considerazione che l'individuo, pur isolatamente studiato, è una parte, un elemento di quel popolo, che la dottrina politica ha proclamato sovrano e per la volontà del quale esiste e si esprime la volontà dello Stato. E si verificò, da un lato, una realtà statuale, che si risolse nel centralismo; dall'altro una realtà individualistica, che si risolse nell'atomismo. Per il centralismo, esistette la potestà assoluta dello Stato; per l'atomismo ogni individuo, che fece parte dello Stato e della società, venne considerato rispetto al suo simile uguale e di eguale valore; ed ognuno fu isolato e autarca nello sviluppo della propria attività.

Ma il rapporto, o l'antitesi diretta, fra individuo e Stato viene modificato e corretto dall'esistenza e dal riconoscimento di altri elementi, che rappresentano l'intermedio, l'aggregato sociale, la collettività. Da questo concorso, il trinomio individuo, collettività e Stato si costituisce nell'unità di un complesso rapporto ⁽¹⁾. Infatti, se pur si guarda la vita pratica, l'individuo non è posto direttamente di fronte allo Stato e non si trova in contatto immediato con l'ente supremo, almeno nella maggior parte delle circostanze e nelle circostanze più importanti della sua esistenza. Fra l'individuo e lo Stato vi ha sempre un numero crescente di corpi intermèdi, che debbono essere integrati nello Stato, perchè i rap-

(1) Vedi più innanzi n. 112 e segg.

porti sociali, che interessano il diritto pubblico, non si esauriscono in quelli che hanno per termini l'individuo da un lato e lo Stato dall'altro; e, nella considerazione di tali rapporti, non si può prescindere dall'esistenza delle collettività e delle organizzazioni.

78. L'uomo va soggetto a due precise tendenze inerenti alla sua natura: a) la tendenza che lo dirige verso la vita sociale, il che lo porterebbe a confondere, in parte, la propria individualità, a perdere un poco della sua personalità e a rinunciare, in parte, alla propria primitiva libertà, in cambio dei benefici, che dalla vita sociale possono ritrarre la sua utilità e il suo interesse; b) la tendenza, che lo porta verso l'affermazione e il mantenimento della propria personalità e la conseguente difesa della propria libertà, il che lo porterebbe ad estraniarsi e a distinguersi dalla massa, per mantenere il più possibile intatti i requisiti, le prerogative e le iniziative della propria vita individuale.

In ogni manifestazione della vita sociale attuale si assiste sia alla limitazione della personalità e della libertà in favore e per gli scopi dell'aggregato sociale, sia all'affermazione della personalità e della libertà come espressione del proprio particolare valore. La nostra dottrina tien conto delle due tendenze dell'uomo, le coordina e le regola, ottenendo che l'aggregato, che sorge per il concorso degli uomini, non sia né una somma atomistica di individui molteplici, né una compatta compagine, dove ogni individualità scompare. Per ciò la nostra dottrina costituisce la pluralità in unità perfetta, lasciando sussistere gli elementi, che la compongono. Con questo la nostra dottrina, mentre cura le sorti degli aggregati, difende anche le sorti degli individui, incoraggiando l'affermazione della loro personalità ⁽¹⁾.

(1) Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Governanti e governati del nostro tempo*, Milano, 1933, p. 80, 81.

Il corporativismo, come dato sociale della rivoluzione, può essere designato come la dottrina della collettività organizzata, vale a dire la dottrina dei rapporti sociali tra l'individuo, la collettività e lo Stato.

Sul valore di questa dottrina corporativa occorre essere precisi, per tre ragioni. Dapprima per una ragione di principio, per smentire cioè la tendenza, secondo la quale la dottrina del fascismo riposa sulla negazione dell'individuo; infatti la collettività organizzata nel sistema corporativo, non è affatto esclusiva, perchè permette lo sviluppo e l'espressione dell'esistenza dei singoli, superandoli, disciplinandoli, ma non annullandoli. La seconda ragione è una ragione di struttura, per la quale non è possibile considerare il complesso, vale a dire la collettività e poi lo Stato totalitario, senza partire e considerare l'elemento e il valore iniziale, vale a dire l'individuo. La terza ragione è una ragione di proporzione, per cui non hanno valore fondamentale solo gli attributi e gli interessi dell'individuo, in sè stesso considerato; ma devono essere tenuti presenti la posizione della sua libertà rispetto all'ente collettivo e all'autorità dello Stato, la proporzione del suo interesse rispetto ad altri interessi affini, concorrenti o preponderanti, e la coordinazione della sua volontà con altre volontà inferiori, eguali o gerarchicamente superiori ⁽¹⁾.

79. Si è accennato che la morale fascista è essenzialmente una morale organica. Secondo questa morale dell'organicità, l'uomo non va più inteso e concepito come un valore atomistico e come un'essenza egoistica della vita sociale sotto il segno dell'individualismo; e neppure esso va inteso come un elemento indistinto e schematizzato o industrializzato sotto i segni del collettivismo;

⁽¹⁾ Vedi BERTOLOTTO G., *Lo Stato e la dottrina corporativa*, v. I, p. 170, e segg.

ma l'individuo è concepito nella sua verità umana, nella quale esso è membro consapevole d'una più alta società spirituale, ma è anche membro attivo di una società disciplinata, nella quale si concreta un organico sistema di valori sociali.

La morale fascista esprime pertanto il suo pieno carattere sociale, perchè essa determina la posizione e l'orientamento dell'uomo, così da soddisfare alle esigenze della sua intima essenza e delle sue tendenze sociali. Avviene, in tal guisa, la socializzazione dell'individuo, vale a dire, come noi l'intendiamo, la determinazione sociale dell'individuo, in forza di quel processo, che noi abbiamo chiamato di *superamento* dell'individuo nella vita sociale.

Per questo intervento di vincoli spirituali e perchè l'individuo, nell'ambiente corporativo, mantiene ben precisata la sua personalità, noi dobbiamo nuovamente porre in evidenza la differenza, che esiste fra la nostra concezione corporativa e la concezione organica od organicistica della vita sociale, come da altre dottrine è prospettata. Innanzi tutto perchè la concezione organicistica sente di materialismo e di rispondenza fisiologica, senza considerazione dell'apporto spirituale recato al tutto da ogni elemento che compone la vita sociale; ed in secondo luogo, perchè la concezione organica od organicistica, che riproduce esattamente la vita materiale, considera l'organo agente e vivente in quanto fa parte del tutto e agisce per cieca necessità, senza aver coscienza del proprio funzionamento nè di quello degli altri elementi. Invece nella concezione corporativa ogni elemento ha coscienza di sè e della funzione sociale che esso compie, non in cieca dipendenza dal tutto, ma in coordinazione cogli altri elementi e in subordinazione gerarchica col tutto (¹).

(¹) Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Lo Stato fascista e la nazione*, Roma, 1931, p. 89 e segg.

Noi intendiamo qui esprimere ed illustrare la collettività organica e corporativa, ben distinta dalle collettività pluralistiche ed atomistiche del liberalismo, che non sono altro che masse d'individui ravvicinati unicamente dai propri personali egoismi; e distinta pure dai collettivismi classisti, che sovrappongono la classe agli individui annientandoli. Qui si tratta della collettività organica e corporativa, come ente intermedio tra l'individuo e lo Stato e che fra l'uno e l'altro mantiene e regola i rapporti e le attività per la realizzazione dei comuni interessi e avendo come principale obiettivo il conseguimento dell'interesse generale ⁽¹⁾.

80. Vi possono infatti essere due concezioni della società civile: una concezione atomistica e una concezione corporativa. La concezione atomistica, portata dalla dottrina individualistica, considera la società come una semplice somma di individui, come una composizione di unità, ognuna delle quali vive a sè stante, per il proprio interesse, nella vita comune. Secondo tale dottrina gli individui sono, rispetto al corpo sociale, quello che sono gli atomi rispetto al corpo fisico, che si aggregano e si disgregano, a seconda che agiscono sovra di essi forze determinate di coesione o di repulsione.

Ma la dottrina atomistica è falsa, perchè, innanzi tutto, si basa su principii nettamente materialistici, dai quali l'uomo è cancellato e misconosciuto nel suo valore spirituale, per assumere un valore puramente positivo,

⁽¹⁾ È la costruzione, indicata colla voce « corporazione » (vedi DEL VECCHIO GIO, *Individuo, Stato e corporazione*, in « Saggi intorno allo Stato », Roma, 1935, p. 87 e segg.), che rispecchia veramente il concetto e l'idea, ma alla quale preferiamo, per maggior chiarezza di esposizione, sostituire l'espressione « collettività organica corporativa » mantenendo ad essa il concetto di un ente che si compone in unità e che acquisterà personalità giuridica senza alterare l'autonomia e la personalità giuridica degli individui o degli enti che la compongono.

empirico ed attuale; e perchè la compagine sociale, come l'individuo, viene considerata nella sua realtà momentanea e transitoria e non nella sua evoluzione storica.

Storica ed organica è invece la dottrina corporativa, che, per raggiungere l'equilibrio fra l'individuo, la collettività e lo Stato, reca alla sua radice la visione dell'uomo come valore morale prima ancora che come valore sociale; e per questa significativa, profonda e salda base spirituale, la concezione corporativa della vita sociale si ispira alle idee della solidarietà, della collaborazione e della gerarchia.

In questo senso le collettività sono gli enti superindividuali, che organizzano o valorizzano l'individuo senza deprimerlo od annientarlo. L'errore e il danno della dottrina liberale è stato quello di ignorare e di opporsi a quelle realtà sociali, le quali rappresentano una necessità della vita comune; mentre la nostra dottrina, che sta lontana così da un'eccessiva rilassatezza come da una indebita compressione ⁽¹⁾, «risolve il triplice problema dei rapporti fra Stato e individuo, fra Stato e gruppi e fra gruppi e gruppi organizzati» ⁽²⁾.

Le collettività, che in questo sistema si compongono, assumono la loro chiara espressione nei vari campi: nel campo morale diventano istituti, scuole ed enti educativi; nel campo sociale diventano gruppi organizzati; nel campo economico diventano associazioni professionali e corporazioni; nel campo giuridico e politico diventano persone giuridiche e organi dello Stato.

Ma queste collettività hanno un piano per la loro formazione, rappresentato dalla nazione, che si può chiamare la collettività generale organizzata. In questo «dato», rappresentato dalla «base nazionale» per l'or-

⁽¹⁾ Vedi più sopra n. 23.

⁽²⁾ MUSSOLINI B., Messaggio dell'anno IX ai Direttori federali convenuti a Palazzo Venezia il 27 ottobre 1930.

ganizzazione degli enti collettivi, si esprime la differenza fondamentale della nostra dottrina rispetto alle altre dottrine. Mentre per le altre dottrine e per gli altri regimi, in tutti i campi in genere ma specialmente in quello economico, le collettività si costituiscono come organizzazioni classiste su base internazionale, la nostra dottrina costituisce invece le collettività con organizzazione interclassista su base nazionale. Ed allora la nazione diventa, nel campo politico il partito unico, nel campo economico il sistema corporativo, in quello sociale la società nazionale, nel campo morale e spirituale la Patria.

Il sistema dell'ordine e della gerarchia degli elementi e dei valori sociali, si costituisce pertanto in forma unitaria e generale sulla base della nazione e sotto la guida dello Stato. Alle varie organizzazioni particolari, rappresentate dai ceti, dalle caste e dalle classi, si sostituisce un'organizzazione generale unica, rappresentata dalla società nazionale e dallo Stato totalitario, nella sua sintesi fra la società e lo Stato.

81. Così l'ordinamento corporativo ha abolito il dualismo, che esisteva, negli ordinamenti passati, tra società e Stato. Da quando, facendo la storia dei movimenti sociali, si dava la nozione di società come organismo di forze, ordini e movimenti, distinti dallo Stato, l'essenza dell'aggregato sociale fu sempre considerata come qualche cosa di lontano e di antagonistico alla struttura e all'ordinamento statale.

Lo Stato era l'organismo giuridico, la società era l'organismo economico-sociale. La dottrina del XIX secolo ci ha fornito le figure d'una società antistatale e di uno Stato antisociale, o, per essere più esatti, extrasociale.

La società fu fuori dello Stato, perchè dapprima non si voleva che tra individuo e Stato vi fossero elementi, i quali spezzassero l'immediatezza del rapporto giuridico.

tra l'uno e l'altro; e inoltre perchè il sistema assegnava al dominio dell'individuo e delle sue organizzazioni tutta la sfera dei rapporti economici, mentre allo Stato era affidata la sfera dei rapporti giuridici.

La divisione tra società e Stato doveva pertanto necessariamente verificarsi; e così la società divenne il campo d'esplicazione delle così dette libertà contro lo Stato, mentre lo Stato era il campo d'esplicazione della così detta autorità contro l'individuo.

Ma se, conforme alla classica definizione, la società è un'unità di vite umane, una partizione di beni, un organismo produttivo e legato a un sistema di bisogni in continuo sviluppo; se l'esperienza insegna che una società civile non può vivere e progredire, senza che sieno soddisfatte talune esigenze fondamentali, che corrispondono a condizioni essenziali di vita; e se queste non possono essere raggiunte se non coll'ausilio del diritto, non è possibile concepire la società disgiunta dallo Stato, che crea e mette in funzione l'ordinamento giuridico.

Non solo, ma, poi che la società ha bisogno di questo elemento essenziale, di questa realtà organizzata, non si può concepire una società civile, che non sia ordinata a Stato, perchè lo Stato solo è espressione di energie, di poteri, di garanzie, di tutela d'interessi e di protezione d'ordinate attività.

Lo Stato non è qualche cosa di materialmente sovrapposto alla società come un complesso di organi e di funzioni; ma è lo stesso spirito animatore d'un sistema giuridico e politico, nel quale convergono e dal quale irradiano tutti i raggi, che compongono una reale unità. Si è infatti rievocata l'antica definizione dello Stato come «l'espressione potestativa della società», ma sempre impersonata in un soggetto di valore unitario ⁽¹⁾.

(1) Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Lo Stato e la dottrina corporativa*. Vol. I. pag. 29 e segg.

Così la dottrina fascista afferma che una società civile non può essere pensata che nelle specie dello Stato; alla stessa guisa che dev'essere pensata come Stato la nazione ⁽¹⁾. Lo Stato fascista, a differenza dello Stato individualista, è sociale e politico; sociale, è fortemente sociale, in quanto esso è fortemente organizzato su basi sociali; politico e autoritario, perchè, per fronteggiare i conflitti e per dirigere i gruppi, esso deve appoggiarsi a un energico potere di governo ⁽²⁾.

82. Lo Stato, nell'espressione assunta presso di noi di Stato-nazione, si realizza come Stato compiutamente sociale nell'ambito nazionale, o, più esattamente, di quella società determinata, che si riconosce in una nazione. È lo Stato nuovo, che si identifica colla società nazionale ⁽³⁾.

La pretesa società mondiale, auspicata dagli internazionalisti e l'ipotesi conseguente dello « Stato mondiale » stanno fuori di ogni esperienza storica ⁽⁴⁾. Lo Stato, è l'unità sistematica ed organica generale e totalitaria, nella quale si costituiscono e si compongono altrettante unità sistematiche ed organiche di valori, quanti sono i campi, ai quali i valori stessi attengono e si riferiscono. In essi ciascuna unità parziale contribuisce e concorre, come elemento organico e presupposto, a formare l'unità superiore e a costituire, in definitiva, a traverso una formazione e un ordinamento gerarchico, l'unità organica e sistematica superiore e generale, vale a dire lo Stato. E lo Stato sarà Stato etico, come unità dei valori morali; Stato sociale, organizzato come complesso dei valori sociali; Stato corporativo, come complesso dei valori economici; Stato autoritario e totalitario, come complesso

(1) MUSSOLINI B., *Stato, antistato e fascismo*, « Gerarchia », 25 giugno 1922

(2) PANUNZIO S., *Dottrina generale dello Stato*, cit., p. 17.

(3) COSTAMAGNA C., *Storia e dottrina del fascismo*, p. 178.

(4) COSTAMAGNA C., Op. cit., p. 227, 228.

dei valori politici; Stato costituzionale, come complesso di valori giuridici e di poteri pubblici ⁽¹⁾. Tutte le specie di attività debbono plasmarsi e conformarsi alla struttura dello Stato, che ne è la formale unificazione, perchè la varietà e la ricchezza delle attività degli individui e degli enti sociali ed economici si ricollegano e si coordinano alla vitalità e al vigore dell'organismo statale. E lo Stato deve astenersi da ogni arbitraria oppressione degli individui o limitazione alla sfera di attività degli elementi sociali, perchè ogni atto di cotale natura si risolve in un indebolimento della compagine dello Stato, mentre la valorizzazione degli individui e delle aggregazioni sociali porta ad un rafforzamento e ad un aumento di potenza e di prestigio dello Stato ⁽²⁾.

In questo modo l'ideale organico, totalitario e corporativo trova la sua realizzazione più completa nell'unità e nella gerarchia dei valori della vita; perchè la determinazione di questa organicità sistematica non è data da un impulso materialistico ed esteriore, ma ben piuttosto da una spinta iniziale ed interna, come coscienza e come volontà di tutto un popolo, che si riconosce nazione, vale a dire unità morale e storia iniziale e che si organizza integralmente nello Stato, che è espressione di personalità politica e giuridica ⁽³⁾.

83. Lo Stato non è meramente una forza che si imponga meccanicamente senza nessuna radice nella coscienza delle masse e degli individui. Esso è innanzi tutto l'organizzazione delle volontà per il conseguimento dei fini etici della vita ⁽⁴⁾; ed è la coordinazione e la subordinazione di tutti gli interessi per la realizzazione

⁽¹⁾ Vedi più innanzi n. 225 e segg.

⁽²⁾ Vedi BORTOLOTTO G., *Lo Stato e la dottrina corporativa*. Vol. I, pag. 172 e segg.

⁽³⁾ Vedi MARCHELLO G., *La morale eroica del fascismo*, p. 92, 93.

⁽⁴⁾ Vedi più innanzi n. 193.

dell'interesse generale, che si compendia nel benessere dei singoli e nell'incremento della potenza nazionale.

Il Duce ha scritto: « *Non c'è concetto dello Stato, che non sia fundamentalmente concetto della vita: filosofia o intuizione, sistema di idee, che si svolge in una costruzione logica o si raccoglie in una visione o in una fede; ma è sempre, almeno virtualmente, una concezione organica del mondo* » (1).

Concezione realistica, vivente, organica. Sistema di idee, alla cui solidità concorrono il mito, la fede, la missione; ma che deve tuttavia ricondursi a una costruzione logica e a una concezione organica e positiva, opponendosi alle ideologie astratte, empiriche od utopistiche, che concepiscono le dottrine fuori della vita del mondo.

La nostra dottrina segue gli istinti e le tendenze, le esigenze spirituali e le aspirazioni del popolo; e crea un ordine sociale, che sia ad esso conforme. Infatti, poi che gli individui sono istintivamente animati da una tendenza verso l'associazione e l'unione, è mancante di senno e di opportunità politica ogni norma, che ostacoli tale innata e necessaria tendenza. Poi che gli uomini e gli aggregati sociali tendono verso l'armonia e la concordia, è mancante di senno politico la disposizione che organizzi, ad esempio, le attività produttive conforme a interessi particolari di classe, per metter le une contro le altre in posizione di antagonismo e di lotta. Poi che gli individui e gli aggregati, il popolo e le compagini sociali, per un innato bisogno di difesa, di tutela, di protezione e di giustizia, vanno verso lo Stato e verso la legge, è assolutamente impolitico il principio, che fa del popolo un elemento di autogoverno e che pretende di porre gli aggregati contro l'autorità costituita e contro lo Stato. Poi che ogni compagine sociale possiede un passato, una storia, un complesso di tradizioni, alle quali

(1) MUSSOLINI B., *Dottrina*. I, 1.

essa è attaccata e devota, è senza giustificazione avviare le compagini sociali per una via, che è diversa o che, peggio, va a ritroso di questo patrimonio, che ogni popolo vuol mantenere intatto.

La vita e lo Stato, che ne costituisce la realizzazione giuridica, organica ed integrale, vanno esaminati, specialmente sotto i riflessi della nostra dottrina, nella loro espressione unitaria, vale a dire nel complesso organizzato di tutti gli elementi che li compongono e che si compongono in unità sotto forme ed aspetti distinti, che l'uno coll'altro si completano e si fondono.

ORIGINS AND DOCTRINE OF FASCISM

With Selections from Other Works

GIOVANNI GENTILE

**Translated, edited, and annotated by
A. James Gregor**



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This work is dedicated to
PAOLINO LEONE
who died in battle at the age of eighteen.

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Introduction to the Translations

A. James Gregor

One of the better interpreters of the thought of Giovanni Gentile, Augusto Del Noce, identified Gentile's *Origini e dottrina del fascismo*, the translation of which is herewith provided, as a "document of major importance."¹ In Del Noce's judgment, Gentile's short exposition on its origins and doctrine was crucial to understanding Fascism's intellectual, emotional, and political substance.

Gentile's exposition in the *Origins* was clearly intended for an Italian audience.² As a consequence, the historic context behind his account is largely unknown to Anglo-American readers. Figures like Antonio Rosmini, Vincenzo Gioberti, and Ugo Foscolo are totally unfamiliar to an English-speaking readership. There is, perhaps, a vague familiarity with the name of Giuseppe Mazzini, but few could identify many of the tenets of his thought. Granted all that, knowledge of specific Italian literary, philosophic, and political personages is not essential in order to appreciate Gentile's account of the origins and doctrine of Fascism.

Gentile's claim is that Italy's involvement in the First World War was characterized by several important features: (1) it was initiated by a "directive minority" that succeeded in infusing "masses" with their conviction; and (2) it was not fought for the acquisition of material gain. Those claims set the stage for the further exposition.

The first contention reflected Gentile's considered judgment concerning complex political events. "History," Gentile was convinced, "is not made by heroes nor by masses; but by heroes who sense the inarticulate, yet powerful, impulses that move masses. [In the making of history] the masses find a person who succeeds in making explicit their obscure moral sentiments. The moral universe is that of the multitudes; and multitudes are governed and energized by an

idea whose precise features reveal themselves to but few, an *elite*, who then proceed to inspire masses to give form and life to history.”³

That interpretation of the dynamics of social change was shared by most of the significant social thinkers of the last quarter of the nineteenth and the first quarter of the twentieth centuries⁴—and Gentile was convinced of the merit of that assessment before there was an organized Fascism. He had expressed that characterization in his essays, written for more popular audiences, as early as 1918—before the manifest appearance of a Fascist movement.⁵

The second contention found in the opening pages of *Origini e dottrina del fascismo* referred to the common motive that bound together nationalists, revolutionary syndicalists, Futurists, and philosophical idealists. That motive, while “ideal” rather than “material,” was not the defense of France or the United Kingdom—nor was it to protect “democracy” against the impostures of the “authoritarian” Germans and Austrians. The purpose of intervention in the First World War, “with or against Germany,” was *the redemption of Italy*, begun with the Risorgimento, the nineteenth century effort to unite the Italic peninsula in a single nation. “Entry into the war,” Gentile argues, “was necessary in order to finally unite the nation through the shedding of blood.” Only that could create a “true nation,” one that would “make itself valued and of consequence in the world.” The purpose of Italy’s intervention in the First World War was to finally participate in the making of history—never again to live “in the shadow” of others.⁶

For Gentile, the First World War brought into sharp relief the “two souls” of contemporary Italy, one that sought the continuation of the efforts of the Risorgimento, and the other that lapsed back into the behaviors of the “old Italy”—the Italy of empty rhetoric, passivity, egoistic amoralism, velleity, and anarchy. The first sought an Italy that was united and integral, that was “serious,” with a seriousness that was religious in character, and infused with faith. It was a “soul” that sought the grandeur of the nation. Gentile identifies that “soul” with the thought of Giuseppe Mazzini.

In his exposition, Gentile seeks to establish a direct continuity between that thought, the Risorgimento, and Fascism. It was an effort that was to continue throughout the Fascist period, and found expression in the notion that the Fascist revolution was one that was “conservative”—preserving the revolutionary elements of Italy’s

modern political and economic developments of the preceding century in order to construct upon them.⁷

The effort was clearly designed to serve several purposes, one of the most important of which was to provide an answer to Benedetto Croce's claim that Fascism represented nothing more than a radical discontinuity in Italy's *liberal* political development. By the time that Gentile wrote the *Origins*, Croce had assumed an anti-Fascist intransigency, and his argument was employed to make of Fascism a meaningless "parenthesis" in the history of the nation.

Fascist intellectuals were to argue that Fascism drew on living elements of Italy's past—and was a perfectly comprehensible consequence of their accelerated revolutionary maturation.⁸ Fascist intellectuals argued for continuity and anti-Fascists argued for discontinuity. It is a dispute that remains unresolved to this day. The notion that Italy immediately before, and certainly after, the First World War, was a divided, if not fragmented, nation is not in dispute. That there were "two Italies," one of which was "Mazzinian," and the other "anti-Mazzinian," was a common conviction. What is more interesting is the fact that Mussolini himself, apparently under the influence of Gentile, gradually accepted the distinction—and ultimately appealed to Mazzinian ideas to support his political positions.⁹

The "Mazzinian" ideas with which Fascism came to be infused were "Mazzinian" only in so far as Mazzini's ideas were interpreted by Gentile. Gentile saw in Mazzinian convictions philosophical idealism, a call to national mission, a consuming morality, a seriousness of purpose, religiosity, anti-individualism, totalitarian unity, an invocation to selfless duty, and the centrality of the state—all functional requirements for a nation undergoing late economic and industrial development in the early twentieth century, in an international environment dominated by hegemonic "plutocracies."¹⁰

None of this is difficult to understand. We have witnessed similar postures, political and social, assumed by revolutionary movements and revolutionary regimes in places as diverse as Eastern Europe, Latin and Caribbean America, the Middle East, Asia and, on occasion, in Africa. What distinguishes Gentile's thought, in some measure, is its insistence on *liberty* and *freedom* as the critical center of Fascist revolutionary thought.

Anglo-Americans have long suffered a curious intellectual affliction: they have been prepared to entertain a conviction that Marx-

ist-Leninists—who have supervised some of the most thoroughgoing totalitarian political systems of the twentieth century—were nonetheless committed to a host of positive normative convictions such as equality, democracy, and freedom. They have *not* been prepared to consider the possibility that Fascist intellectuals held some of the very same convictions. Western intellectuals were prepared to argue that Marxist-Leninist intellectuals were betrayed by their leaders in the violation of equality, democracy, and freedom. They were *not* prepared to consider the same argument with respect to any Fascist commitment to such values. Marxist-Leninist intellectuals were betrayed; Fascist intellectuals were simply liars, frauds, and mountebanks.

The truth is that Gentile held *freedom* and *liberty* to be central normative convictions of Fascist doctrine. We may argue that such values were betrayed by Fascism, but we cannot insist that a case for them was not made by Fascist intellectuals. Gentile argued that the Fascist state was fundamentally *democratic* and predicated on *liberty*. For Gentile, the concepts were legitimately contested.

For Gentile, only when the individual fully identifies with the community, and its expression in the state, is *true* freedom and democracy possible. Like Marxist-Leninists, Gentile held that the individual is unreal, restricted, and unfree, outside the multiple relationships established in community with others. The individual for Gentile is, in essence, a *communal-being* (a *Gemeinwesen*). Full freedom and democracy for such a creature finds expression only in identity with the community (in Gentile's case, with the nation and its political expression in the state). How that identity is achieved is argued in Gentile's technical philosophical works.¹¹ For the purposes of the present rendering, Gentile provides a non-technical account in the selections herewith provided from his *La riforma dell'educazione* where the initial thoughtless "freedom" of students is reconciled with the "true freedom" of unity with the "authority" of informed instruction.

For Anglo-Americans, who have limited access to the Italian literature of the Fascist period, it is important to appreciate that Mussolini recognized that Gentile provided the normative rationale for Fascism and that whatever objections were raised, by both Fascists and anti-Fascists, Gentile's views would ultimately prevail. For Mussolini, Gentile was the philosopher of Fascism.¹²

Gentile provides an answer to the prevailing folk-wisdom of political science that Fascism was anti-intellectual, irrational, mind-

less, and inhumane. Whatever inhumanity, thoughtlessness, and perversity can legitimately be attributed to Fascism cannot be the consequence of the lack of a reasonably well-articulated and measurably persuasive normative doctrine. In dealing with Fascism as a doctrine, one can do no less than traditionally has been done with respect to Marxism-Leninism as a doctrine: one must consider it dispassionately and objectively in terms of the criteria employed to measure the credibility of *any* body of political thought.

The provision of a translation of the *Origins and Doctrine of Fascism* in its entirety, and selections from *What is Fascism* and *The Reform of Education*, are supplied as insights into the doctrine of Fascism, the debt of that doctrine to the thought of Giovanni Gentile, and the continuity of doctrine in time prior to the advent of Fascism. As has been argued elsewhere, Fascism grew out of the despair and humiliation of an Italy that had long been subject to the pretensions of the advanced industrial democracies.¹³ It found its intellectual and normative rationale in the thought of Giovanni Gentile.

Some liberties have been taken in the translations, and no attempt has been made to preserve Gentile's singular literary style—sometimes baroque and sometimes synoptic. Rather, it is hoped that the translations are relatively easy to read and understand—and that they faithfully convey something of the substance of Gentile's ideas.¹⁴ Inserts appear within brackets, and annotations appear in the endnotes with the intention to clarify or augment some matters that arise in the texts. Footnotes are presented as they appear in the original Italian.

Notes

1. Augusto Del Noce, *Giovanni Gentile: Per una interpretazione filosofica della storia contemporanea* (Bologna: Il mulino, 1990), p. 300.
2. Gentile prepared other works for foreigners, "The Philosophy of Fascism," herewith provided was one and the *Dottrina politica del fascismo*, prepared for the "Course in Fascist Doctrine and Activity for Foreigners" for the University of Padua, was another.
3. Giovanni Gentile, *Dottrina politica del fascismo* (Padua: CEDAM, 1937), p. 18.
4. See A. James Gregor, *The Ideology of Fascism: The Rationale of Totalitarianism* (New York: Free Press, 1969), chap. 2.
5. Giovanni Gentile, *Dopo la vittoria: Nuovi frammenti politici* (Rome: La Voce, 1920), pp. 5-8.
6. At the end of the Fascist experiment, Mussolini is reported to have said that Fascism was an effort to end "eighteen centuries of invasions and misery,...of servitude, of intestine conflict and ignorance." Benito Mussolini, *Testamento politico di Mussolini* (Rome: Pedanese, 1948), p. 33.

7. See Sergio Panunzio, *Lo stato fascista* (Bologna: L. Cappelli, 1925), pp. 21-30.
8. See Gioacchino Volpe, *Italia in cammino* (Rome: Volpe, 1973), pp. 7-24 and *passim*.
9. Del Noce, *Giovanni Gentile*, pp. 300, 330.
10. See A. James Gregor, *Italian Fascism and Developmental Dictatorship* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1979).
11. There are a number of works available in English that provide insight into Gentile's technical philosophy, included among them are H. S. Harris, *The Social Philosophy of Giovanni Gentile* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1960); Roger W. Holmes, *The Idealism of Giovanni Gentile* (New York: Macmillan, 1937); Pasquale Romanelli, *The Philosophy of Giovanni Gentile: An Inquiry into Gentile's Conception of Experience* (New York: Bimbaum, 1937); and A. James Gregor, *Giovanni Gentile: Philosopher of Fascism* (New Brunswick, NJ: Transaction Publishers, 2001).
12. Del Noce, *Giovanni Gentile*, pp. 310, 312, 323; see Yvon De Begnac, *Palazzo Venezia: Storia di un regime* (Roma: La Rocca, 1950), pp. 540, 541, 619, 641 and Gisella Longo, *L'Istituto nazionale fascista di cultura: Gli intellettuali tra partito e regime* (Rome: Antonio Pellicani, 2000), chap. 1.
13. See A. James Gregor, *Phoenix: Fascism in Our Time* (New Brunswick, NJ: Transaction Publishers, 1999), chap. 2.
14. Two major works of Gentile are available in English: Giovanni Gentile, *The Theory of Mind as Pure Act* (New York: Macmillan, 1922) and *Genesis and Structure of Society* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1960).

Origins and Doctrine of Fascism*

I. The Divided Spirit of the Italian People before the First World War

For Italy, its involvement in the First World War was the resolution of a profound spiritual crisis. It is from that reality that one must commence if one wishes to understand the slow and laborious maturation of some spiritual aspects of the nation's decision, in the first months of 1915, to enter into combat against the Central Powers, who at that point in time, were Italy's allies. From that point one can understand why the war had such singular moral and political consequences for Italy. The history of the war is not to be understood only in terms of a tissue of economic and political interests and military actions. The war was fought, first willed, then sensed and conceived worthy, by Italians: by a people composed of a majority led by a directive minority. It was willed, felt, and valued with such spirit that it could not be dismissed by Italy's statesmen and military leaders. They had to deal with it. More than that, the popular spirit influenced them and conditioned their actions. It was a spirit that embodied a sentiment that was not altogether clear nor coherent, neither easily determinable nor recognizable in general. There was neither unity at the outbreak of the war nor at its conclusion. At the end of the war, the different tendencies were no longer subject to the discipline which, during the war, had been imposed. That discipline was the result of the will of some, as well as the necessity of circumstances. After the war, there was no agreement [among Italians] because, to overlook the minor variations, there were in the nation's soul two distinct currents, representing essentially two irreducible souls. They had struggled for two decades, doggedly contesting the field, in the effort to achieve that reconciliation that seems to always require a war fought and a final victory—for the triumph of one. In such a contest, only the victors can conserve that which is salvageable from the vanquished.

* *Origini e dottrina del fascismo* (Rome: Libreria del Littorio, 1929).

One need only refer to the tortured history of Italian neutrality—to understand that there were not simply two political opinions or two historical conceptions that found themselves opposed, but two souls, each with its own fundamental orientation and its own general and dominant exigency. The enflamed polemics between the interventionists and those who chose noninvolvement, the different postures that the arguments of the interventionists assumed, the facility with which they accepted all the ideas, the most diverse and opposed, that were offered in support of intervention, and the means, of every kind, which the neutralists employed to defeat what they sincerely conceived to be the supreme tragedy of war testified to that.

For the one, the essential thing was to make war: with Germany or against Germany. To enter the war, to throw the nation, willing or unwilling, into the conflict—not for Trento, Trieste or Dalmatia, and certainly not for specific political, military or economic advantages that those annexations might provide, nor for the colonial acquisitions that others anticipated. These particular ends, of course, were to be taken into account. But entry into the war was necessary in order to finally unite the nation through the shedding of blood. The nation had been formed more through good fortune than through the valor of its sons—more the result of favorable contingencies than through the strength of the intrinsic will of the Italian people—a will conscious of itself, its interest in unity and its right to unity.

The war was seen as a way to cement the nation as only war can, creating a single thought for all citizens, a single feeling, a single passion, and a common hope, an anxiety lived by all, day by day—with the hope that the life of the individual might be seen and felt as connected, obscurely or vividly, with the life that is common to all—but which transcends the particular interests of any. The war was sought in order to bring the nation together—in order to render it a true nation, real, alive, capable of acting, and ready to make itself valued and of consequence in the world—to enter into history with its own personality, with its own form, with its own character, with its own originality, never again to live on the borrowed culture of others and in the shadow of those great people who make history. To create, therefore, a true nation, in the only way the creation of every spiritual reality is undertaken: with effort and through sacrifice. That which frightened the others—the wise men, the realists—was the thought of the moral risks to which the war would

expose a young nation, never having been tested in a national conflict, not sufficiently prepared, neither morally nor materially, for such a trial, not sufficiently established in its structure to throw itself into a conflict that threatened the nation with collapse on the occasion of its first test. Among the wisest of the wise there was the calculation that neutrality in the war might produce more abundant benefits than victory in that war: tangible, determinate, material benefits, those which, for the pundits of politics, are the only ones worthy of consideration.

That was precisely the point of contention. The neutralists calculated, and the interventionists committed themselves to the war for an intangible, impalpable, nonmensurable moral concern—at least in terms of the judgment of others. That moral concern, however, proved to be more weighty than all the rest for those who accepted it. It is evident that calculations of advantage, of whatever order there might be, presupposes that there are those who profit, who are in a position to profit, and gain advantage. They defend and sustain all that as though it were important to one's selfhood. The fact is that the development of one's personality is the foundation and the principle of everything.

But everything can be nothing, for the individual and for peoples, without the will which can, and should serve, to make determinations of value. The will and the consciousness of self, character, individuality solid and powerful, are among the greatest riches that dying parents can leave their children, and which provides the inspiration for those statesmen who work for their people.

In the political conflicts before the advent of the Great War, Italy's duality of soul was manifest; one expression was to struggle against the neutralism of public opinion with ever-increasing insistence. The neutralists sought to resist involvement in the war not through the government, the center of legally constituted political power, but through Parliament. Parliament, at that time, seemed the source of all initiatives, the very foundation of the State. The Parliament became increasingly menacing and its behaviors more and more irreconcilable with the nation's executive, as though intent upon bringing the nation to the very threshold of civil war. That fratricidal war was avoided only through the intervention of the King, who provided the government the power to declare war.¹ That was the first decisive step toward the solution of the grave moral and political crisis [that characterized Italy before its involvement in the war].

II. The New Italy of the Risorgimento

The crisis of which we have spoken, had remote origins, with roots deep in the Italian spirit—a spirit of recent history, easily isolated, the end result of the secular development of its civilization. Italy's more recent history is that of the Risorgimento—the national movement of reunification of the nineteenth century—at which time this new Italy awakened and sought to arise and affirm itself. What were the active forces of the Risorgimento, together with the complex of external and internal conditions within which they were to operate?

There was the mass of the Italian people, to whom some historians today tend to attribute a notable if not predominate influence; there was English sympathy and French assistance; there was the war between Prussia and Austria, and between Prussia and France, and so forth, that could only but have impact on the Risorgimento. Without Cavour, Napoleon III would never have fought in Lombardy. But the primary causal agent is always an idea become person, with a will that pursues determinate ends—a cognizant will that has a program to realize, a concrete thought, effective in history. There is no doubt that the Risorgimento was the consequence of the labor of a few; and could be nothing other than the labor of a few. The few, in so far as they were the conscience and the will of an epoch, were the agents of history. They recognized the forces that were available, and employed that which was really the only active and effective force available to them—their own will.

That will was the thought of poets, of thinkers, of political writers, who at times know how to speak a language that resonates with a universal sentiment—capable of being its embodiment. From Alfieri to Foscolo, from Leopardi to Manzoni, from Mazzini to Gioberti they wove together a new fabric that was a new thought, a new spirit, a new Italy—that would distinguish itself from the old through a simple, but enormously important feature: it would take life seriously while the older Italy would not. Throughout history there was talk of immortal Italy; it was the subject of song; it was proposed in prose and in rhyme—with every form of argument. It always was an Italy lodged in the thought of intellectuals, and in doctrines more or less remote from life, in which those who take things seriously are required to draw out the implications of convictions and translate ideas into action. It was necessary that Italy de-

scend into the hearts of Italians, together with all the other ideas relative to life's realities, there to become positive and vital elements. [To understand that is to understand] the significance of Giuseppe Mazzini's motto: thought and action. That was the greatest revolution anticipated and realized by him. He inculcated into many the conviction that only that thought which expressed itself in action was real thought. Those who responded—it must be remembered—were a minority—but sufficient to raise the issue where it could be publicly considered. Life was seen not as a game, but a mission. The individual has a law, a goal, through which he discovers his proper value, and for which sacrifice is necessary, with the individual forfeiting private comforts and daily interests, and, should it be necessary, his life [in order to reach that goal]....

No revolution displayed more of these features of idealism, of thought that preceded action, and its satisfactory outcome, than did the Risorgimento. It was not life's material needs or diffuse popular sentiments that erupted in revolutionary disturbances. The demonstrations of 1847 and 1848 were the work of intellectuals—as one would say today—and in the majority of cases, the result of the actions of a minority of patriots, who were the bearers of those ideals and who would move both rulers and the populace to their realization. There has never been a revolution, in that sense, that was more idealistic than that which fulfilled itself in the Italian Risorgimento.

Idealism is a faith in an ideal reality that must be sought. It is a conception of life that must not limit itself to present fact, but which must progress and transform itself incessantly in order to conform to a superior law that acts upon souls with the force of the soul's own convictions. Idealism was the very substance of the teachings of Mazzini.² That idealism, well or ill understood, was the spirit of our Risorgimento; and because of the moral influence which it exercised and the recognition with which it was received outside of Italy, revealed the historic character of that great event to the world. Gioberti, Cavour, Vittorio Emanuele, Garibaldi, and all those patriots who labored at the very foundation of the new kingdom were, in that sense, Mazzinians.³ The entire Risorgimento was Mazzinian, not only in terms of the political forces in act, but in all the forms of the spiritual life of Italians, in which the influence of Mazzinianism matured independently of his writings and enjoinders. Writers of

the first rank, like Manzoni and Rosmini, who had no historic relationship with Mazzini, shared the same traits, and on convergent paths, pursued the same end: to plant a conviction in souls—a conviction that life is not what it is, but what it ought to be; and only that life is worthy of being lived which is as it ought to be, with all its duties and difficulties, requiring always efforts of the will, abnegation, and hearts disposed to suffer in order to make possible the good—an anti-materialistic and essentially religious conviction.⁴ One can run through the series of the writers and thinkers of the time. There is not a single materialist among them—not one who does not sense the religious character of life—who, irrespective of the political contrasts found between national aspirations and the dogmas and exigencies of the [Roman Catholic] Church, did not acknowledge, in some fashion, the necessity of reinvigorating the religious sentiment and revive in souls that faith, which for Italians had become no more than a formal and mechanical externality. Even Giuseppe Ferrari (who might be considered the exception) confirms the truth of the judgment—he who ultimately found himself in absolute solitude, opposed not only by Gioberti and the moderates, but by Mazzini himself. Ferrari was a restless, turbid, contradictory, inconclusive spirit, formidable in the brilliant quality of his genius and his vast culture, inept in his destructiveness, and incapable of construction.

The religion of Gioberti is not that of Rosmini, nor that of Manzoni. That of Mazzini is not that of Tommaseo, to compare spirits that shared affinities. Between Cavour and Ricasoli, who both keenly sensed the gravity of the religious problem—as a problem for both the individual and as a political problem for the new Italy—the difference is even greater. One of the thinkers more versed in religious matters is Lambruschini—who is studied even today with much interest for the freshness and profundity of his religious ideas, remains a solitary figure. In effect, one cannot speak of an Italian religious movement during the first half of the nineteenth century—a movement that had a character and a program, in which many participated. Nonetheless, at the bottom of all the variety of ideas and tendencies, there was a shared basis—a faith in the reality and the power of the ideal principles that govern the world. [It was a faith in which there was] a common opposition to materialism. That was the general character of the time. That was the ground on which everyone met and could agree or disagree.⁵

III. The Waning of the Risorgimento and the Reign of Umberto I

That religious and idealistic conception of life, which formed the basis of the national patriotic conscience of the Risorgimento, dominated and governed the spirit of Italians until its exhaustion as an historic movement. It was the atmosphere in which one breathed not only during the heroic times until the proclamation of the new Kingdom with Cavour, but also afterwards, in the period of the *diadochi*, from Ricasoli to Lanza, Sella, Minghetti, until the occupation of Rome and the establishment of the finances of the State,⁶ until the time that the work appeared complete, the Risorgimento concluded, and the moment when the people of Italy, having become a nation through severe trials and hard discipline, were to be launched to democratically and freely develop their inherent economic and moral forces. The parliamentary change of 1876 signaled, if not the end, the arresting of the process with which Italy began the century—with that spirit we have attempted to describe.⁷ The process was changed. It was changed not through caprice, confusion, or the weakness of persons, but as an historical necessity, that it would be foolish, today, to deplore. Rather, it behooves us to understand what transpired. It seems that liberty had been conquered, because from 1861 through 1876, Italian politics was directed by the Right, which was scrupulously concerned with statutory liberty—but which conceived liberty in a manner distinct from the Left. The Left moved from the individual to the State; the Right from the State to the individual. Those of the Left conceived the people—for a variety of reasons, and according to their origins and their different intellectual development—as the same as the citizens of which the "people" are composed. The Left made the individual the center and the basis of rights and initiatives—that any regime of liberty was required to respect and guarantee. The persons of the Right, on the other hand, as the result of various tendencies and modes of thinking, were firm and in agreement concerning the notion that one could not speak of liberty without speaking of the State. A serious liberty with important content could not obtain other than within the sound organism of a State, whose sovereignty would be the indestructible foundation of all its activities. The [State was understood to be the arena in which the] play of the interests of individuals is conducted. They possess no liberty worthy of mention that is

not compatible with the security and authority of the State. The general interest is always to be given priority against any particular interest—to thereby absolutely and irresistibly endow the life of the people with value. A convincing concept, but not without dangers. Applied without regard to the motives out of which the opposed concept of the Left arises, and appears justified, it can result in stasis, immobility—and therefore in the annihilation of the life which the State embodies in itself and disciplines in the organic substance of its relations, but which it must not, nor can, suppress. [Only a State that responds to the considerations out of which the concepts of the Left emerge can remain vital and progressive. If the State fails to respond to those considerations] it becomes a form indifferent to content, alien to the things it must regulate; it becomes mechanical, and threatens to overwhelm those things with which it must deal.

The individual, in turn, who does not find the law within himself, does not become one with the State and opposes the State and the law. He senses the law as a limit, as a constraint, that would suffocate him should he not be able to free himself. That was the feeling of those of 1876. The people of the nation required more breathing space. Moral, economic, and social forces needed to develop without being further confined by a law that was not understood. That was the cause of the political change. From there our new nation entered into a period of growth and development—economic (industrial, commercial, rail transport, financial, and agricultural), as well as intellectual (scientific and scholarly), development. All to the credit of the reign of Umberto I. The nation that had received, as from on high, a form, arose, and made every effort to lift itself to a higher level, giving to the State that had already crafted its statutory codes, its administrative and political institutions, its army and its finances, a living content of real forces. Those forces grew out of the enterprise, both individual and collective, that were put in motion by the interests that the *Risorgimento*—all caught up in the grandeur of the political purpose to be attained—had not satisfied.

The most important minister of King Umberto, Crispi, aggressively sought to stop that movement of growth, to raise once again the flag of idealism—even religion—that he had been given in his youth by Mazzini, himself. He revealed a misunderstanding of his time, and fell before the violent reaction that the so-called democracy unleashed against his effort.

It was necessary, for the time being, to fold away the old and glorious banner. One was not to speak of wars, nor of anything that might signify and require national pride and consciousness of a program to be undertaken in competition with the Great Powers. One was not to dream of assuming any pretense of being on the level of the Great Powers or their proper equal. It was enough to participate in discussions with them, and return content that one's hands remained unsullied [by the acquisition of territory or resources so common among the "powers" at the end of the nineteenth century.] One was not to think of limiting individual liberty in the interests of that abstract and metaphysical entity that was called the State. One was not to call upon God (as Crispi was wont to do). One must allow the popular classes to gradually conquer well being, a sense of self, and enter politics. Education and the battle against illiteracy, together with all the other provisions of social legislation were to be undertaken. The removal of Church education and the introduction of secular public schools were sought.⁸ There was everywhere and in every way a struggle against long-established and pernicious ecclesiastical influence, and the associations that arose to achieve that goal were to remain in Italy to pursue that end [at the beginning of the twentieth century]. Masonry continually penetrated, expanded, and branched out throughout the national administration and the military, into the magistrature and the schools.⁹ The central power of the State was weakened, bent to the attitudes of the popular will by means of universal suffrage and the votes of parliament. That will was increasingly liberated from the limitations of the superior obligations of life....Less authority, more liberty.

The character of public life was shaped from below. And to increase the impetus and the force, there was socialist propaganda, of Marxist stamp, to which the rise and development of heavy industry opened the way. That was accompanied by a new form of moral education for the working classes and the formation among them of a political consciousness. It was a revolutionary consciousness, together with a sentiment of human solidarity, new to the primitive and unsophisticated psychology of the Italian lower classes. A new discipline came with the associations and federations of classes—but it was a partial and narrow discipline that limited the moral horizon and ruptured the majority of the ligaments with which the human being is morally connected to others. More than anything else, it did not allow the social awareness that draws human beings

together in the service of interests, sentiments, and thought of a single Fatherland.

For the Left, the bonds that maintain and establish the community, which were conceived as respectable and to be respected, were all rooted in the sentiment that each instinctively has of conquering and defending his own proper well being—a *materialistic* conception of life against which Mazzini had struggled.¹⁰ It was that conception that Mazzini opposed in socialism—but which he himself recognized was not limited to socialism, but was common to every political conception, liberal as well as antisocialist, that was democratically individualistic—in so far as life was conceived as devoted entirely to the satisfaction of rights rather than the discharge of duties. Liberalism and socialism are both individualistic in so far as both deny a reality superior to that material life which has its measure in the individual. Materialists are always individualists.

The Italy of the Left, from 1876 until the war of 1915-1918 was materialistic and anti-Mazzinian—even though it goes without saying that it was an Italy far superior to the Italy of pre-Mazzinian times. The light of the Risorgimento went out. Other than a few survivors, whose voices lost themselves in the desert, all of culture, in the moral sciences, as well as in the natural sciences, letters, arts, and education, was dominated by a crude positivism, which even when it protested that it did not wish to deal with metaphysics—seeking to remain in agnostic reserve—lapsed into materialism, conceiving reality as a finished something that limited and conditioned the lives of human beings, and which ultimately dominated them beyond every exigency and moral pretext. Morality was considered arbitrary and illusory. Everyone spoke of facts, of positive things. They ridiculed metaphysics and any reality that might be intangible. The truth was in the facts. One needed only to open one's eyes to see the mirror of truth in nature. Of God, it was said, it was better not to speak. Concerning the soul one might speak but only to conceive it as a physiological phenomenon which one might well observe. Patriotism—like all the other virtues that have their origins in religion, concerning which one could no longer speak unless one was prepared to speak with gravity—became simply an issue of inflated speech, which one ought to have the good taste not to consider.¹¹

This—as it remains in the memory of those educated during the last quarter of the nineteenth century—was the spirit of that anti-

Mazzinian age, with the exception, once again, of a few faint voices, collected together in a common feeling. It was an age that could be politically designated a demo-socialist phase of the Italian State, because in Italy the democratic mentality found expression in socialism, an imposing and primary force. It was the age, as has been indicated, that filled the entire reign of Umberto I. It was a period of development and prosperity, in which the creative forces of the Risorgimento were overwhelmed and obscured.

IV. Idealism, Nationalism, and Syndicalism

During the final years of the nineteenth, and in the first three years of the twentieth century, youth found itself enveloped and transported by a new spirit, a forceful reaction to the dominant ideas in politics, literature, science, philosophy, and in the culture of the last quarter of the preceding century. Italy seemed fatigued, repelled by the prosaic, middle-class, materialist life that it endured. It was eager to return to its origins, to the ideas, the high aspirations, and the great moral forces that had given Italy birth. At the turn of the century, Rosmini and Gioberti had been generally forgotten. They survived only in cults having few adepts. Their books were rarely found in the bookstalls and among used bookdealers. Their names were barely spoken by scholars who had pretensions of being current. [By the first decade of the new century, however,] they returned with honor, and around their doctrines a new literature began to arise that saw in their thought something of great permanent value. The royal government itself decreed the publication of a national edition of the works of Mazzini. There was a return to the study of his life and writing, not only as a matter of historical interest but also as a source of instruction that could no longer be overlooked. Vico, the great Giambattista Vico,¹² the philosopher of the highest speculative national tradition, the formidable advocate of the anti-Cartesian idealist and spiritual idealist philosophy, was once again passionately studied together with other national thinkers. Italians could sense and reconstruct an autonomous and elevating consciousness of the proper personality of the nation. More recent writers (Spaventa, De Sanctis), who were not able, in life, to break through the resistance of those too obtuse to recognize the idealistic needs and the intimate intelligence of life and art, returned in honor, were republished, read, and universally studied.

Positivism, as it found expression in its major and minor representatives, was refuted—it was opposed, rejected, and satirized in all its forms. Materialistic methods of study in literature and art were fought, and discredited. The doors of Italian culture were opened to new ideas—ideas which, even beyond the Alps, substituted themselves for positivism and naturalism. The old Roman Catholic conscience was shaken, reawakened, and revived by the modernist movement that had been born in countries possessed of a more vital ecclesiastical culture.¹³ It found ardent agents among young priests who, participating in the critical studies of the history of Christianity and the philosophic studies in which the movement found its origin, awakened among Italian clerics the need of a culture more modern and profound. They took effective part in religious controversies and struggles. They succeeded in bringing to light problems that had long remained in the shadow for Italians. Orthodox Catholics, modernist Catholics, and non-Catholics saw those problems with new eyes and more sensibility.

In the renewed philosophic and critical spirit, socialism itself no longer appeared to be a finished doctrine to be accepted as dogma. It was rather seen as a doctrine, like every other, that would have to be studied in its essence and structure. Italian scholars gave themselves over to the example and guide of the French, who had been dogmatic adherents of Marxism. Together, both the Italians and the French reviewed Marxism's weaknesses and errors. When Georges Sorel, as a consequence of that critique, defeated that materialistic theory of the German social democratic epigones of Karl Marx—and advocated syndicalism—young Italian socialists turned to him, and found in syndicalism two things: (1) the rejection of that strategy of foolish and deceptive collaboration of socialism with the parliamentary democracy of the liberal State. In so doing, socialism succeeded only in betraying the proletariat as well as the liberal State. (2) [As opposed to standard socialism, the proletariat found in syndicalism] a faith in a moral reality, exquisitely ideal (or "mythic," as was said at the time), for which one would be prepared to live, die, and sacrifice oneself, even to the point of using violence whenever violence was necessary to destroy an established order to create another. It was an anti-parliamentarian and moral faith that transformed the conscience of workers in syndicates, and made of the socialist theory of duties a Mazzinian conception of life as apostolic obligation.¹⁴

Another idea suggested by French culture—that had enormous impact on the youth of Italy and thereby penetrated deeply into the community, particularly among intellectuals, and which profoundly reformed political thought—was nationalism. Less literary and more political in Italy because closer to a political current that had an immense importance—the traditional Right—around which Italian Nationalism collected itself, emphasizing the ideal of the Nation and the Fatherland. It was emphasized in a form, as we shall see, that was not entirely acceptable to the traditional Right. The new form had to be forthcoming; one which advanced the conviction to which the Right had remained committed: to the State as the foundation in which the value and right of citizens was anchored. Nationalism, whatever the case, was a new faith lit in the Italian soul, thanks to which the Fatherland was no longer spoken of with socialist derision. The courage was mustered to resist the arrogance of socialists—that the liberals of various democratic persuasions found irresistible. Nationalism had another virtue: that of openly and boldly raising objections to that Masonry before which everyone in the Italian bourgeoisie had timidly prostrated themselves—save the Roman Catholics, who had directly opposed it. The anti-Masonic battles fought are among the signal honors of Italian Nationalism.

Masonry, parliamentary socialism, more or less reformist and democratic, became the common targets of the syndicalists, the Nationalists and the idealists: bound in a common cultural ideal and in a common conception of life. They had returned in unison, consciously or not, to a religious and idealistic Mazzinian conception. Separated by many of the articles of their special programs, they were nonetheless united and committed in that fundamental concept. They sought to infuse a consciousness of renewal and a vigorous sentiment of opposition among the youth [of Italy] against the prevailing culture and politics. During the first fifteen years of the century there was a ferment in newspapers, magazines, in the publications of the new publishing houses, and among the youth groups that had begun to organize. There was an emergence of new growth, of new forces, that turned to the remote past to recall to life the energy that would sustain hope for the future. They were innovators who made recourse to tradition. They were polemicists, sometimes violent, who advocated a system of order and restoration of ideal forces, in which everyone would have to subject themselves

to the discipline of law. They appeared reactionary to the radicals, to the super-liberals of a democracy influenced by Masonry, and to the reformists of socialism. They were, rather, the heralds of the future.

Official Italy, legal and parliamentary, was opposed to them. The Italy of post-World War One had as its leader a person who possessed a secure intuition of collective psychology, an expert in the vices and virtues of the entire political and administrative mechanism in which anti-Mazzinian and anti-idealistic Italy had established and secured itself. He was skeptical or indifferent to high ideals, a simplifier of all the great questions, and a simplifier in terms of solutions. He was ironic, incapable of enthusiasm and grand affirmations for himself or for the nation that he was obligated to faithfully serve. He was a positive person, practical, crafty—a materialist in the Mazzinian sense.

The two antithetical currents that characterized pre-World War One Italy were identified with the names of Mazzini and Giolitti. The crisis that arose out of their mutual opposition was to be resolved only with the war. Only then was Italy to be freed of that dualism that wounded and paralyzed it—to create a unified soul and produce the consequent ability to act and to live.

V. The Post-War Prostration and the Return of [Giovanni] Giolitti

From the very beginning, the effect of the war was not what had been expected. The end of the state of war in 1918, released the people of Italy from the limitations and constraints of wartime discipline—releasing them to the freedom of normal circumstances. The right to free and open expression of their intentions was restored. Given the latitude made available by the renewal of parliamentary and popular liberty, the political and juridical order felt the weight of the popular will. Under that weight, the State gave evidence of unraveling—together with the moral forces that provided it support. Popular sentiment seemed to support the position of those who did not want Italy to enter the war—those who had done everything possible to impede that eventuality. It seemed that those so disposed were prepared to further test the already sorely tried nation and the limits of the State's strength. Popular sentiment seemed to argue that it had been unreasonable, arbitrary, and foolhardy to commit a young and poor people, not yet united as a national community,

and without a military tradition, to the arduous challenge of international conflict. The socialists considered the expression of that sentiment a confirmation of their original position with respect to the war. They intoned hymns of victory and triumph. They felt that their resistance to Italy's participation in the Great War had been justified and the truth of their judgments demonstrated by the facts. At the end of the war, Italy's allies had turned their backs on her, minimizing Italy's sacrifice and the value of its contribution to the Allied victory. For Italy, justice would not be forthcoming.

There were Italians who perversely took pleasure in the frustration of the hopes of those who advocated intervention. They were not disturbed—as right reason would seem to dictate—by foreign malevolence. They seemed rather to welcome the abuse. There was an increasing appeal to democratic ideology toward which there had been far too much indulgence during the war. The intervention of the United States in 1917 brought with it the acceptance of a democratic ideology of the worst kind, that of Woodrow Wilson.

The Italian victory in the Great War was thus transformed into a defeat; and a sense of defeat diffused itself among the people of the nation: hatred of the war and of those responsible for Italy's participation in it. That hatred extended to the military that had served as an instrument in that war. There was hatred of that system that had made the war possible at all, by making Parliament (and what a Parliament it was!) unable to oppose it. In fact, the sentiment against the war was so emphatic that a minister of the monarch was found who proposed that the lower house of Parliament abrogate Article 5 of the Statuto, thereby making the declaration of war a prerogative, not of the King, but of the Head of the Government [the first minister]. With the unleashing of those singularly materialistic anti-national passions, there was diffused throughout the nation, together with an arch discontent, an anarchic disposition to undermine authority itself. The ganglia of economic life appeared thoroughly impaired. Work stoppage followed work stoppage. Its very bureaucracy opposed the State. Public services ceased or were disorderly. A lack of faith in the action of the government, and in the force of law, grew day by day. A sense of revolution permeated the atmosphere which the weak ruling class felt impotent to resist. Ground was gradually ceded and accommodations made with the leaders of the socialist movement.

The specter of Bolshevism loomed as a terrible menace. Giolitti—that execrated Giolitti of the beginning of the war, the “man of Dronero,” who throughout the war was gradually forgotten by Italians, or who was remembered only as an exponent of that Italy that had died with the war—resurfaced. He was invoked as a savior. Under him, however, there was sedition among the employees of the State and the occupation of the factories by workers; the very economic organism of the administration of the State was mortally wounded. Those who had inflicted the wounds were treated with diplomacy—an open confession of the State’s debility. Had Giolitti, thanks to the consequences of the war, triumphed over Mazzini?

VI. Mussolini and the Fasci di Combattimento

Under the government of Giolitti, however, the circumstances changed, and against the Giolittian State there arose others who were authentic opponents, those who had willed the war and had consciously fought it—those who on the fields of battle believed in the sanctity of sacrifice. On those battlefields more than a half million lives were immolated for an idea. It was they who felt how great a crime it would be if all that bloodshed would one day be seen as having been in vain (as their opponents anticipated). It was they who sought to kindle in the hearts of Italians, and in Italian history, the glory of the victory consecrated by the sacrifice. Among them were those magnificent men who had been mutilated, who had seen death up close, and who, more than other survivors, felt possessed of the right conferred on them by those many, many thousands, who had made the supreme sacrifice, to watch and judge the living. They, the mutilated and the dead, awaited that Italy for which they had been called upon to sacrifice and for which they had given their limbs and lives. They were Mazzinians, in effect, who had wanted the war, and who had gone to war, before all the others. They provided spiritual guidance and prompted faith in the youth of Italy. They found a powerful voice that gave precise expression, nobly and energetically, to their convictions, unconquered by the disillusionment and prevailing meanness of spirit. They found a man who spoke for all, who spoke above the tumult, and who made those listen who sought not to allow the precious heritage of the war to be lost. He was a man who understood how to speak to the heart, who roused and mobilized all the passions invoked by bloody trenches

and victorious combat. [Those heroes of the war] saw shining as from a distant height, a burning will: that of Benito Mussolini.

Benito Mussolini had emerged from Italian socialism in 1915 in order to become a more faithful interpreter [of the will of] the people of Italy, to whom he, already editor of the socialist paper, *Avanti!*, wished to devote his new journal, *Il popolo d'Italia*. He argued for the necessity of the war, for [Italy's entry into] which he was among those truly responsible. Just as he had struggled against Masonry while a socialist, inspired by Sorellian syndicalism, he opposed the parliamentary corruption of reformism with the idealistic postulates of revolution and violence in the name of revolution. Outside the ranks of official socialism, he continued his battle against his old comrades, defending the rationale of the war, defending the infrangible moral and economic wholeness of the national organism, against the lying fictions of internationalism. He argued for the sanctity of the Fatherland—[something that would be sacred] even for the working classes. He was a Mazzinian with the sincerity that Mazzinianism always found in Romagna. He had already transcended the ideology of socialism—first by instinct and then by reflection. Having passed through a painful and troubled youth, rich with experiences and meditation, he had nurtured himself with the most recent [anti-positivist and anti-materialist] culture of Italy. [He gave himself over to the concept of] that great Italy, which he—together with all those young men who, throughout the war—longed for and passionately loved. All had grown with the new ideas of the century, and in the new faith in the ideal—against the demagogic and anarchist velleities of those socialists who preached revolution with neither the force nor the will to undertake it. [Those failed socialists were persons who] even on the most propitious occasions failed to recognize the necessity of assuring the most essential condition for the existence of a nation: a State form that would be truly a State, with a law to be respected, with an authority that made itself respected, possessed of a worth that would legitimate that authority. A nation—that was capable of sustaining a war that was in every way arduous, long, and bloody—a nation continuously victor over itself, tenacious in controlling the forces in act, making sacrifices in the constancy of a faith perpetually renewed, irrespective of deficiencies, disappointments, and tremendous reversals, achieving victory, in effect, through its own virtue—could be thrown into disorder and degradation without the respect and authority required by

the State. The debasement of the State was accomplished by a few men like Treves, Turati, and their like—men without faith, political aesthetes, with all the brilliant culture of journalists, together with arid and empty hearts. On the 23rd of March of 1919, in Milan, at the site of Mussolini's newspaper, *Il popolo d'Italia*, the first Fascio di Combattimento was founded. In response to the will of its Leader—the destructive and negative post-war movement [in Italy] was soon to be halted. The Fascists called together those Italians who—the disappointments and the anguish that came with peace notwithstanding—continued to have faith in what the war, and what the victory in that war, meant. They sought to restore Italy to itself, through the reestablishment of discipline and the reordering of social and political forces within the State. Fascism was not an association of believers, but a party of action, that had need not of programs of particulars, but of an idea, that indicated a goal, and thereby a way to be followed with a resolute will—that refused to acknowledge obstacles, because ready to overcome them.

Was that will *revolutionary*? Yes, because it anticipated the construction of a new State.

VII. Redemption

The twenty-third of March 1919 was the date when the redemptive counteroffensive began—when out of Milan a cry was raised that awakened the spirit of the veterans who had wanted the war and who had fought it—who had sensed its value, and who had faith in their idea, notwithstanding the frustrations of a peace that was neither glorious nor just, and notwithstanding the vile spectacle of an ignorant people swept up in the arrogance of skeptics. The skeptics had been negative on the eve of the war; they opposed the war during the long, dark, and anxious days of trial, and they denied it, with malign smiles, after victory bore little fruit and reward. After the victory, they continued to maintain that the carnage was pointless, and those who had willed the war were to be deplored, scorned, and persecuted. Those who had worked for the victory were despised and derided. The spirit of the nation was prostrate. The consciousness of the sanctity of the nation—of the will that governed it, of the law that was its essence and which took form in a living person—was lost. The least noble passions of humankind were released and stirred. A revolution threatened that was without

ideas or energy. It had bred during the long postwar inertia—like disease bacteria—that undermined the living body from within. It was a potential revolution without the strength of revolution, without the ability to destroy in order to create. It was a negative revolution. It was said that it was Bolshevik—but it was worse than Bolshevik. Against that revolution the veterans arose, mobilized by that powerful cry that in 1915 had given expression to their faith and had nourished it thereafter. They collected themselves in *Fasci*, associations that quickly multiplied throughout the nation.

And those associations made a revolution: a revolution that was possessed of an idea, a will, and a Leader. It had all begun with the war, declared in a manner that had already mortally wounded the Parliament, reducing to rubble the legal objections that obstructed the realization of the profound national will of a people who sought the dignity and power of their nation.

That revolution was undertaken and pursued with energy until the goal was attained. The illegalities of the four-year period (1919-1922) constituted the necessary condition for the manifestation of the national will—until the 28th of October 1922, when the old State was brushed aside by the impetus of the new youthful faith, and the *Fasci* became the new Italy.

From that day, the new nation reconstructed itself, because that powerful cry had by that time awakened all Italians, and animated and guided them in their arduous labor.

VIII. Squadristm

The four year period 1919-1922 was characterized, in the development of the Fascist revolution, by the deployment of Fascist squads. The action squads were the military force of a virtual State. [They were the military arm of a State] in the process of realizing itself—which in order to create a superior regime, violated the controlling laws of a moribund State system—understood as inadequate to the demands of the national State sought by the revolution. The March on Rome of the 28th of October 1922 was not the beginning, but the conclusion of that revolutionary movement, which on that date, with the consequent constitution of the Mussolini ministry, assumed full legality. From that point, Fascism, as the directive idea of the State, underwent evolution, slowly creating the institutions necessary for its actuation and its investment of all the economic,

juridical, and political arrangements which make up the State, and which the State guarantees.

After the 28th of October 1922, Fascism no longer confronted a State that was to be destroyed; Fascism became the State and proceeded against those internal factions that opposed and resisted the development of those Fascist principles that were expected to animate the new State. Fascism was no longer a revolution against the State, but a revolutionary State mobilized against the residue and internal debris that obstructed its evolution and organization. The period of violence and revolutionary illegality had ended—although the activity of the squads continued for a time to flicker here and there—in spite of the iron discipline imposed by the Duce of Fascism and Head of the Government. Mussolini sought to have reality conform to the logic that governed the development of his idea and that of the Party that incarnated that idea. Fascism possessed all the means necessary for reconstruction: it transformed its own illegal action squads into the legal voluntary militia—in which the spirit of the revolution would be maintained until the fulfillment of the revolutionary program.¹⁵ The Party was established in an inflexible and perfect hierarchy obedient to the intentions of its Leader, and was rendered an instrument of government action, ready, with spirit, to face the test. The Italy of Giolitti was finally overcome, at least in the realm of armed politics. Between Giolitti and the new Italy—the Italy of the combat veterans, of the Fascists, and believing Mazzinians—flowed a river of blood. That torrent barred the way to anyone who advocated turning back. The crisis was transcended, and the war began to bear fruit.

IX. The Totalitarian Character of the Doctrine of Fascism

The history of the Italian spiritual and political crisis and its solution was immanent in the concept of Fascism. How the legislative and administrative actions of the revolutionary government dealt with that crisis is not the present object of discussion. Rather, the present account is intended to illuminate the spirit which the government brought to its activities—which, in five years, profoundly transformed the nation's laws, orders, and institutions—thereby revealing the essence of Fascism.

It has already been said that before the complexity of the movement, nothing is more instructive for understanding it than, as we

have already indicated, to consider Mazzini.¹⁶ His conception was a political conception—a conception of integral politics, a notion of politics which does not distinguish itself from morality, from religion, or from every conception of life that does not conceive itself distinct and abstracted from all other fundamental interests of the human spirit. In Mazzini, the political man is he who possesses a moral, religious, and philosophical doctrine. Should one endeavor to separate, in Mazzini's creed and in his propaganda, that which is merely political from that which is his religious, his ethical intuition, moral enjoinders, his metaphysical convictions, one can no longer account for the great historical importance of his belief system and his propaganda. One can no longer understand the reasons why Mazzini attracted so many to himself—and proceeded to disturb the sleep of so many men of State and of the police. The analysis that does not always presuppose a unity [at the base of Mazzini's thought], does not lead to a clarification, but rather to a destruction of those ideas that exercised such historic consequences. It is evidence that human beings do not deal with life in slices, but rather as an indivisible unity.

The first point, therefore, that must be established in a definition of Fascism, is the totalitarian character of its doctrine, which concerns itself not only with political order and direction of the nation, but with its will, thought and sentiment.

X. Thought and Action

The second point. The doctrine of Fascism is not a philosophy in the ordinary sense of the term, and still less is it a religion. It is also not an explicated and definitive political doctrine, articulated in a series of formulae. The truth is that the significance of Fascism is not to be measured in the special theoretical or practical theses that it takes up at one or another time. As has been said at its very commencement, it did not arise with a precise and determinate program. Often, having settled on an immediate goal to be attained, a concept to be realized, a course to be followed, it has not hesitated, when put to the test, to change direction and reject as inadequate, or violative of principle, just that goal or that concept. Fascism sought not to bind the future. It has often announced reforms that were politically opportune, but the announcement itself did not bind the regime to their execution. The real commitments of the Duce are al-

ways those that are formulated and undertaken at one and the same time. For that reason Mussolini has always considered himself a "tempist," that is to say a person who undertakes a solution and acts at that proper moment in which action finds all the conditions and reasons mature that render the action possible and opportune. Fascism draws out of the Mazzinian truth, *thought and action*, its most rigorous significance, identifying the two terms in order to have them perfectly coincide, no longer to attribute any value to thought that is not translated or expressed in action. That is the source of all the expressions of "anti-intellectualist" polemics that constitutes one of Fascism's most recurrent themes. It is a polemic that is eminently Mazzinian, because "intellectualism" [as "intellectualism" is understood by Fascists] divorces thought from action, science from life, the brain from the heart, and theory from practice. It is the posture of the talker and the skeptic, of the person who entrenches himself behind the maxim that it is one thing to say something and another thing to do it; it is the utopian who is the fabricator of systems that will never face concrete reality; it is the talk of the poet, the scientist, the philosopher, who confine themselves to fantasy and to speculation and are ill-disposed to look around themselves and see the earth on which they tread and on which are to be found those fundamental human interests that feed their very fantasy and intelligence. "Intellectuals" are all those who represent that old Italy. They were the enemy of Mazzini's heated preachments.

Anti-intellectualism does not mean, as some ignorant Fascists seem to believe, that they are authorized by the Duce to dismiss science and philosophy. It does not mean that one denies the value of thought and those superior expressions of culture through which thought expresses itself. Spiritual reality is a synthesis, in whose unity one finds expression and value in that thought that is action. In the conclusive unity of that synthesis converge, and must converge, and know that they converge, many elements without which the synthesis would be empty, operating in a void. Among these elements are all the forms of spiritual activity, which share in the same value which is that of the synthesis. All the elements of the synthesis are essential. One does not rout armies that threaten the Fatherland with trigonometry—but without trigonometry one cannot target artillery. Anti-intellectualism is directed against those human beings who exhaust their spiritual life in an abstract and remote intellectual activity, far from that reality, in which everyone should realize that

human existence is rooted. Anti-intellectualism is opposed to those postures that are sometimes assumed that miss superior, more concrete, more humane alternatives. The adversary that first of all is to be defeated is that adversary found among those that are mentally, morally, and historically, typical of that cultivated Italian class, that have been identified for centuries as *literati*. That would include not only authors and cultivators of literature, but every writer, even those writing about science and philosophy, even those who would occupy themselves with liberal studies—that is to say, even those disinterested and nonprofessional—academics, who are erudite, scholars, who would not involve themselves in politics, in real matters, those who would not involve themselves in the practical world. Such persons are the bastard product of our Risorgimento—whom Fascists justly consider bad citizens—the products of a growth which Fascists seek to extirpate.

Such an anti-intellectualism does not imply a hostility to culture, but a hostility to a decadent culture. It is hostile to that culture that does not educate and which does not make, but rather unmakes, the person, rendering him a pedant, an intellectual aesthete. The person is rendered an egoist, a man morally and therefore politically indifferent—one who considers himself superior to the fray, even when the struggle involves his Fatherland—even when interests that should win because their triumph signals the victory of his own and the defeat of enemies. Human beings make progress by dividing themselves through victory in battle and in the success of the one above the other. Woe to those who do not participate in the service of either side, and fail to commit themselves, remaining aloof, conceiving duty to be that of a spectator, awaiting an outcome and taking advantage of it, at the close of a conflict, waiting to partake of the fruits of the victor. The intellectualist sees the summit of wisdom in achieving that state of apathy in which one can consider the pros and cons of everything, extinguishing every passion, finding a place where he might watch, with security, those who suffer and die. But that is the epicurean ideal. All of human history opposes itself to that kind of epicureanism. Human history, heavy with everything we hold dear, in which, and for which, we live, is strewn with trials.

Because of its repugnance to that kind of intellectualism, Fascism is not enamored of tarrying in the making of abstract theories—not because it does not allow the making of theory, but because it does not expect theory to serve as a major force for the

reform or the promotion of Italian culture and life. On the other hand, when it is said that Fascism is not a system or a doctrine, one must not imagine that Fascism is empty of reason, is blind practice, or a method that is indefinable or instinctive. Rather, if one defines as system or philosophy something alive, as a principle of universal character in its very development, a principle capable of revealing, as it develops literally day by day, its creativity together with the results and consequences of which it is capable, Fascism is a perfect system, with a most steadfast principle possessed of a rigorous logic of development. The Duce himself, together with the most humble member of the Party, recognizing the truth and the vitality of that principle, labor for its development, now moving with security along the direct route to the goal, and at other times making and unmaking, now moving forward and at other times returning to the beginning out of commitment to the logic of development—because some effort revealed itself as failing to accord itself with principle.

In that sense—as an open system dynamically capable of development—there is philosophy in every great body of thought, be it a political or social revolution, or a religious reform, or as a moral or critical literary movement. In this sense, the thought of Mazzini is a philosophy, as is the thought of Manzoni, as is that of Pascal as well as Goethe, Leopardi, and as is the thought of Byron or Shelley.¹⁷

None of these belong to the proper history of philosophy, but each belongs to a philosophical current, and they reject all that which deviates or contradicts it. If one fails to understand this, one could not identify or evaluate Fascism. One might consider Fascism a method, more than a philosophical system, because in ordinary language the term system is understood to mean a developed doctrine containing theories fixed in propositions or theorems to which nothing can be added and nothing subtracted. Nothing could be more alien to Fascism than those philosophic or religious doctrines which implicitly entail the rise of a school or sect, with adepts and heretics.

XI. The Center of the System

The third point. The Fascist system is not a system, but has in politics, and in the interest of politics, its center of gravity. Born as a conception of the State, intended to resolve the political problems exacerbated in Italy by the release of the passions of the unthinking masses of the post-World War I period, Fascism took the field as a

political method. But in the act of confronting and resolving political problems, Fascism, in accordance with its very nature, by its very method, posed for itself moral, religious, and philosophical problems—and, in so doing, developed and demonstrated its specific totalitarian character. That provided the occasion for putting the political form of its principle to the fore. In manifesting that principle, Fascism revealed its specific content—without immediately revealing its ideal origins in a more profound intuition of life, from which the political principle arises. This allows us to outline a rapid synthesis of the political doctrine of Fascism, which does not exhaust its content, but which constitutes that part, or better that preeminent, and generally most interesting, expression.

XII. The Fascist Doctrine of the State

Fascist politics turns entirely on the concept of the national State—a concept which has many points of contact with the doctrine of Nationalism—so many points in fact, that it permitted the fusion of the Nationalist Party with that of Fascism in a single program. Nonetheless, the Fascist concept has its proper character. That cannot be overlooked. Without recognizing that, one would neglect that which is peculiar and characteristic of Fascism. Comparisons are never very generous—still less the one here proposed. Nonetheless, the effort will be undertaken to bring to light the essence of Fascism.

Both Nationalism and Fascism place the State at the very foundation of every individual value and right. For both, the State is not a consequence, but a beginning. The relationship between the individual and the State proposed by Nationalism was the direct antithesis of that advanced by individualistic liberalism and socialism. For Nationalists, the State is conceived as prior to the individual. For liberals and socialists, on the other hand, the individual is understood to be something that precedes the State, who finds in the State something external, something that limits and controls, that suppresses liberty, and that condemns him to those circumstances into which he is born, circumstances within which he must live and die. For Fascism, on the other hand, the State and the individual are one, or better, perhaps, "State" and "individual" are terms that are inseparable in a necessary synthesis.

Nationalism, in fact, bases the State on the concept of the nation—an entity that transcends the will and the personality of the

individual because it is conceived as objectively preexistent, independent of the consciousness of individuals. Individuals do not labor to create it. The nation of the Nationalists is something that exists not because of spiritual activity, but as an empirical fact and a datum of nature. The constituent elements that make up the nation are territory or ethnicity—all of the same extrinsic nature, even when they are human in origin, like language, religion, or history. That is because those human elements that combine to create national individuality preexist, and the individual finds them already in existence, until he initiates that moral activity that engages and develops them. Much the same can be said of territory and ethnicity. Naturalism, is the disability that attends the tendentially spiritualistic thrust of Nationalism, and makes of it something inflexible, illiberal, retrograde, and crudely conservative—its least sympathetic element. Before Fascism—with which it was later to assimilate and amalgamate—that flaw made it suspicious and repugnant even to those who politically sympathized with most of its postulates. On the other hand, it attracted certain mysticoreligious attachments that proved to be one of the most effective reasons for the enthusiastic adherence to Nationalist idealism by the youth of Italy and those intellectuals not given to political reflection.

One of the special and conspicuous reflections of naturalism was the monarchial loyalty of the Nationalists. The monarchy was a presupposition for them. The Italian State had been born with its monarchy and by virtue of that, the historic basis that today constitutes Italian nationality includes the monarchy. It is a history that intimately and indissolubly binds a people together. There are the Alps and the Appenines, there is Sicily and Dalmatia, there is the undertaking of The Thousand of Garibaldi, and there is the House of Savoy. With the subtraction of any of these elements, one would no longer have the nation. To agree with that, as one must, is to consent to those elements—to feel them as inseparable from the very personality of being Italian. [For the Nationalists] it is not consciousness, recognizing and feeling the tie or rapport that creates and confers upon them the moral value and the obligation they are due, but it is the natural or historical connection and rapport that preexists, that determines the appropriate consciousness. That consciousness is virtually the product of those preexisting natural elements.

When Fascism sought its own path, on the other hand, it was acutely aware of the tedium and dissatisfaction with the actual po-

litical State of the Italian nation. Fascism was not capable of persuading itself that the monarchy could, with a vigorous effort, energetically react to restore the nation to that path clearly designated by the generous sacrifices of the war and by the victory honorably concluded. Fascism could not imagine what roots that monarchy could have, and maintain, in the reality that was the Italy of Vittorio Veneto. For that reason, Fascism did not hesitate to frankly confess a republican tendency. Later, when Vittorio Emanuele refused to invoke that state of siege proposed by the last prime minister of the old regime against the Fascist March on Rome, and chose to resolve the crisis between the old and the new Italy, as in 1915, by assigning power to the new Italy—resolutely violating the customary norms of the parliamentarianism responsible for the grave crisis—that antimonarchical disposition did not impede Mussolini from taking an oath of fealty to the King, thereby breaking definitively, sincerely and logically from republicanism. That signified that Fascism, unlike Nationalism, saw in the monarchy not the past to be respected as an historic fact, but as something alive in the soul, a future to which the spirit turns as to a proper ideal, an ideal that addresses our aspirations, our needs, our nature.

The monarchy, as with all the determinations of the State, as the State, is not something delivered to us by history; neither is it outside of us. The State is within us, mature, alive and of necessity living and growing and expanding and elevating itself in dignity, and conscious of itself and of its high duties and the grand goals to which it is called, in our will, in our thought, and in our passions. The individual develops and the State develops. The character of the individual consolidates itself, and with that character, the structure, the force, and the efficacy of the State consolidates itself.

Italy's seas, coasts, and mountains seem to acquire more cohesion and integrity as though they were ideas and sentiments. Everything in nature can be divided and disaggregated if it pleases us, or at least does not displease us—and everything can be rendered one and indivisible, if we feel that unity to be necessary. Past history with its memories and traditions, with its vanity and its titles to glory, is reconstituted and finds a place through our interested and fervid spiritual reinvocation. It is the spirit which makes them its own, to support and defend them with its adhesion and vigilant consciousness. The language of our fathers is enjoyed and appropriated—and it revives, being studiously taken in and savored with all its

expressive qualities. It had seemed as though all that had preexisted—an hereditary legacy—but in fact it is transfigured in our own personal conquest and in a continuous creation, that would vanish if we failed to understand that we are its author.

XIII. The Fascist State as a Democratic State

The Fascist State, therefore, as distinct from the Nationalist State, is an entirely spiritual creation. It is a national State, because from the point of view of Fascism, it is the result of spiritual action rather than a presupposition. The nation is never complete—nor is the State simply the nation in its concrete political form. The State is always *in fieri*. It is all always in our hands. It is therefore our own immense responsibility.

But this State that realizes itself in the consciousness and will of the individual, rather than being imposed from on high, cannot have the same relationship with the people imagined by Nationalism. They imagined that the State corresponded with the nation, and conceived both as an already existing entity that it was not necessary to create, but which it was only necessary to come to know. That preexisting entity required a ruling class, characteristically intellectual, that sensed that entity, that first required to be known, understood, appraised, and exalted. The authority of the State was not a product, but a presupposition. It could not depend on the people, in fact, the people depended on the State. The authority that the people were required to recognize was the very precondition of life. Without that authority, sooner or later, one would have to acknowledge that survival was not possible. The Nationalist state was aristocratic state, that constructed itself out of the force it inherited from its origin, that made it valued by the masses. The Fascist State, on the other hand, is a popular state, and, in that sense, a democratic State par excellence. The relationship between the State and the individual is not that between it and one or the other citizen, but with every citizen. Every citizen shares a relationship with the State that is so intimate that the State exists only in so far as it is made to exist by the citizen. Thus, its formation is a product of the consciousness of each individual, and thus of the masses, in which the power of the State consists. That explains the necessity of the Fascist Party and of all the institutions of propaganda and education that foster the political and moral ideals of Fascism, so that the thought and the will of the

solitary person, the Duce, becomes the thought and the will of the masses. Out of that arises the enormous difficulty in which it is involved, to bring into the Party, and into the institutions created by the Party, all the people—commencing from their most tender years. It is a formidable problem, the solution of which creates infinite difficulty, because it is almost impossible to conform the masses to the demands of an elite Party of vanguard morality. Such a conformity could only happen slowly, through education and reform. Equally difficult is the duality between governmental action and the action of the Party. As the Party's organization expands almost to the full extent of the State—whatever the effort to consolidate their efforts through the force and unity of discipline, discrepancies remain. The two, however much the effort is made to make their action one through discipline, the danger remained that there would be difficulty, with every initiative and progress—given that all individuals were bound together in a mechanism that, even though encouraged by a single spirit that emanated from the center and proceeded to the periphery, the freedom of movement and autonomy would only slowly languish and disappear.

XIV. The Corporative State

The great social and constitutional reform that Fascism is accomplishing, instituting the corporative syndicalist regime as a substitute for the liberal State, arose out of the very character of the Fascist State. Fascism accepted from Syndicalism the idea of the educative and moral function of the syndicate. But since the intention was to overcome the antithesis between the State and the syndicate, the effort was made to enter the system of syndicates harmoniously into corporations subject to discipline by the State and to thereby give expression to the organic character of the State. In order to give expression to the will of the individual, the organic State must reach him, not as an abstract political individual that the old liberalism supposed—as a featureless atom. The organic State sought to reach the individual as it could only find him, as he in fact is: as a specialized producer whose tasks moved him to associate himself with others of the same category, all belonging to the same unitary economic organism that is the nation. The syndicate, conforming as much as possible to the concrete reality of the individual, renders him valued for what he is in reality—be it in terms of self-conscious-

ness that he gradually achieves, or from the right he has earned as a consequence of a contribution, through the syndicate, to the general interests of the nation.

This major reform remains in process. Nationalism and syndicalism—together with liberalism, itself—had criticized the old representative form of the liberal State and appealed to a system of organic representation to better capture the reality in which citizens are lodged, and would better represent their psychology and provide support for the development of their personality.

The corporative State seeks to approximate itself to the notion of immanence of the State in the individual. That immanence provides for both the strength of the State [because it is identified with the individual] and the liberty of the individual [because the liberty of the individual is found in the liberty of the State]. That concept provides [the rationale] for the ethical and religious values that Fascism has made its own and which the Duce has regularly invoked in his speeches...in the most solemn manner.

XV. Liberty, Ethics and Religion

On one occasion the Duce of Fascism undertook a discussion of the theme: *Force or Consensus?* concluding that the two terms are inseparable—that the one entails the other—the one incapable of being affirmed without the affirmation of the other. That implies that the authority of the State and the liberty of citizens is an infrangible circle in which authority presupposes liberty and vice versa. Liberty is found only in the State and the State is authority. The State is not an abstraction, an entity that descends from heaven and remains suspended in air above the heads of citizens. Rather, it is all one with the personality of the individual, who for that reason must foster, seek out, and recognize the State, knowing that it is that which he has, himself, fashioned.

Fascism, in truth, does not oppose itself to liberalism as a system of authority against a system of liberty. [It sees itself] rather as a system of true and concrete liberty as opposed to abstract and false liberty. Liberalism commences with the breaking of the circle above indicated—opposing the individual to the State, and liberty to authority. Liberalism seeks a liberty in itself, that confronts the State. It wants a liberty that is the limit of the State, resigning itself to a belief that the State is the (unfortunately inevitable) limit of liberty. These

were abstractions and inanities that were the object of criticism within liberalism itself by those liberals of the nineteenth century who valued and anticipated the necessity of a strong State—in the interests of liberty. The merit of Fascism was that it courageously and vigorously opposed itself to the prejudices of contemporary liberalism—to affirm that the liberty proposed by liberalism serves neither the people nor the individual. Moreover, since the corporative State tends to realize, in the most coherent and substantial manner, the unity and comprehensiveness of authority and liberty through a system of representation more genuine and more in correspondence with reality, the new State is more liberal than the old.

Within that circle [of authority and liberty]—unrealizable except in the sphere of individual consciousness which historically developed in association with the productive forces and in the historic tradition of intellectual and moral conquests—the State could not attain the concreteness to which it aspires and of which it has need, if it did not invest in that sphere all its consciousness as a sovereign force not circumscribed by any limit or condition. Otherwise, the State, in the very intimacy of its spirit, would remain suspended in air. Only that is valuable, and lives, that is entirely spirit—omitting nothing. The authority of the State is not subject to negotiation, or compromise, or to divide its terrain with other moral or religious principles that might interfere in consciousness. The authority of the State has force and is true authority if, within consciousness, it is entirely unconditioned. The consciousness that actuates the reality of the State is consciousness in its totality, with all the elements of which it is the product. Morality and religion, essential elements in every consciousness, must be there, but they must be subordinated to the laws of the State, fused in it, absorbed in it. The human being, who in the profundity of his will, is the will of the State with its synthesis of the two terms of authority and liberty—each acting on the other to determine its development—is the human being who, through that will, slowly solves religious and moral problems. The State, without these determinations and these values, would devolve into a mechanical thing. It would be divested of that value to which it politically pretends. *Aut Caesar, aut nihil.*

Out of this arises the exquisitely political character of the relationships between the Fascist State and the Roman Catholic Church. The Italian Fascist State—for reasons already given—one with the mass of Italians, is either not religious, or it is Roman Catholic. It

cannot be irreligious, because the absolute value and authority it confers on itself would be incomprehensible without a relationship to a divine Absolute. It would be a religion that had a base, was rooted in, and made sense to, the mass of the people of Italy. That would allow the absolute will of the Fatherland, of which there could only be one, to find expression in a religious sentiment. The alternative would be to stupidly fail to develop that which was already in consciousness, or to arbitrarily introduce into consciousness that which it did not contain. To be a Catholic meant to live in the Church and under its discipline. Therefore, it was a necessity for the Fascist State to recognize the religious authority of the Church; a political necessity, a political recognition, with respect to the realization of the State itself. The ecclesiastical politics of the Italian State must resolve the problem of maintaining its sovereignty, intact and absolute, even before the Church, without casting itself athwart the Catholic consciousness of Italians, nor the Church to which that consciousness is subordinated.

That is a grave problem, since the transcendent conception that rules over the Catholic Church contradicts the immanentist character of the political conception of Fascism—which, as has been said, far from being the negation of liberalism and democracy (which even the leaders of Fascism have regularly repeated for polemical reasons) actually aspires to be the most perfect form of liberalism and democracy, in conformity with the doctrine of Mazzini, to whose spirit Fascism has returned.

This is the way. A long, harsh, steep way. The Italian people have commenced on the path with a faith, with a passion, that has taken possession of the soul of the crowd, and for which there are no examples in its history. They undertake passage with a discipline never before experienced, without hesitation, without discussion, with eyes only for that person of heroic temper, gifted with those extraordinary and admirable traits of the great leaders of peoples. That Leader advances, secure, surrounded in an aura of myth, almost a person chosen by the Deity, tireless and infallible, an instrument employed by Providence to create a new civilization.

Of that civilization one can divine that which has contingent value specific to Italy—and that which has permanent and universal value.

Appendices

1. The Philosophy of Fascism*

Every political conception truly worthy of the name is a philosophy, because it is not possible to isolate its proper object—political life in general, the political life of a determinate people in a determinate time—from other forms of human reality, that ordinarily maintain themselves distinctly from politics. Nor can politics isolate itself from universal reality, historic or natural. It cannot be isolated because man with all his activity, when he is not abstractly considered, is intimately related to all reality. Only in such a relationship can the human being understand himself and find guidance. A self-sufficient politics could not serve. Politics invests everything, as does ethics, with which, in a certain fashion, it identifies itself.

Fascism has a full awareness of that truth—and therefore accentuates the ethical character of the conception that it proposes. And, in spite of the polemics against philosophy with which many Fascist writers content themselves, it does attribute a philosophical significance and a universal application to its affirmations as affirmations of principles—whose consequences are of interest not only to politics in the strict sense, but economy, law, science, art and religion itself—in fact, to every human activity, theoretical or practical.

The suspicion and aversion that many Fascists entertain with respect to philosophy are themselves indications and manifestations of the particular character of Fascist thought. As in many similar cases, they are the polemics of one philosophy against other philosophies. Fascism, in fact, polemicizes against abstract and intellectualistic philosophies (the rejection of intellectualism has become the common feature of Fascist literature)—that is to say, those philosophies that presume to explain life by putting themselves outside of it. The Fascist, on the other hand, conceives philosophy as a philosophy of practice (*praxis*). That concept was the product of certain Marxist and Sorellian inspirations (many Fascists and the Duce, himself, received their first intellectual education in the school

* An English language version of this article appeared as "The Philosophy of the Modern State," in the *Spectator*, 3 November 1928, pp. 36-37. The present article has been retranslated from the original.

of Marx and Sorel)—as well as the influence of contemporary Italian idealistic doctrines from which Fascist mentality drew substance and achieved maturity. Fascist philosophy is not a philosophy that is thought, it is rather one that is done. It therefore announces and affirms itself not with formulae, but with action. If it does make recourse to formulae, it attributes to them the same value as actions, in so far as they are expected to produce, not empty words, but practical effects.

From this fundamental character of Fascist philosophy derives those qualities that are spoken of as Fascist *style*—a style of literary expression and a style of practical conduct inspired by an economy and an austerity that would suppress in discourse, as it does in its treatment of facts, every superfluous element, tending to extract from human activity the maximum yield with respect to the superior ends toward which these activities should be directed. With that, the *form* of the Fascist conception defines itself. It is a form that has a determinate *content* which turns on the concept of the State—the center of its entire system of thought. The Fascist State may be defined in negative terms, affirming what it is not rather than what it is. That is so because the Fascist State has arisen as antithetical to the socialist and liberal conception. From that antithesis has arisen the energy with which Fascism has articulated its own conception of the State. It is understood that at the bottom of the anti-socialist and anti-liberal battle there was something positive—the ethical conception of the State as an autonomous personality that has its own value and its own ends, subordinating to itself every existence and individual interest, not to suffocate them, but to recognize them only as realizations of the personality of the State, as consciousness, and as will.

It is an anti-individualistic conception, in so far as it affirms a spiritual reality, a reality that is universal—not the result, but the ideal principle and the original source of the concrete life of individuals possessed of moral value. From that concept a form of the authoritarian State can be logically derived. It is an authoritarianism that is—only for those who do not know how to conceive ideas except in their abstraction—the negation of political liberty. Fascist authoritarianism rejects license—which is not liberty at all. Only through the State can liberty be realized, and therefore has never existed except as it manifests itself as the liberty of the State (not of the individual)—that is to say, the liberty of the State that realizes its

existence in the better part of the consciousness and will of the citizen. That State is an effective existence. There is no question of being or not being concerning the State. The true State is not a State shaped by laws that are infirm and uncertain, prey to the perplexity and doubt that arises from individual judgment, but an institution animated by an unshakable superior and dominant will.

It is an authoritarian State that does not accept the anarchic liberalism of the individualist—who does not recognize the *a priori* and immanent necessity of the State. And yet, it is more liberal than the liberal State itself. The Fascist State, having organized and juridically recognized workers' syndicates and employer organizations, intends to adapt its structure to those united syndicates, to draw them into national corporations, on the way to a system of political representation compatible with the structure of workers' organizations—that is to say, to a system that adapts itself to the immediate concrete conditions of Italy's population, in which one finds the root of popular consciousness. It is a perfection of the representative system which the liberal State could not even imagine. But the national will of Fascism does not derive its political value from fact, but from the idea that informs and explains the history of a people's past and future. The ideal nation—that in the very awareness of its being, incarnates and reveals itself in, and to, few individuals or in a single individual—is more real than the factual nation that might exist, at any given time, in the awareness of ignorant and unknowing multitudes.

The Fascist conception is idealistic and appeals to faith, and celebrates ideal values (family, Fatherland, civilization and the human spirit) as superior to every contingent value. And it proclaims a morality of sacrifice and militancy, in response to which the individual must always be ready to face even death for a reality superior to himself. As a result, Fascism has been moved by its own logic to awaken the religious consciousness of Italians—and seeks to provide for the education of youth in schools and in premilitary institutions, founded and organized in a system that commences in earliest childhood until induction into the military.

2. The Laws of the Grand Council*

Editor's Note: Gentile's discussion of the law regularizing the constitutional role of the Grand Council of Fascism is instructive in so far as he therein signals the transformation of the liberal, parliamentary, into the totalitarian, single party, state. The Grand Council was a council composed of the leaders of the Fascist revolution and, as such, was extra-constitutional from its inception. While composed exclusively of Fascist party leaders, the Grand Council spoke for the entire nation, controlling the initiation and the promulgation of legislation. Until 1928, in effect, the functions of the Grand Council were extra-legal. In that year, the law of the Grand Council to which Gentile refers, rendered the Council's activities lawful. More than that, the law of the Grand Council, for all intents and purposes, made the Head of the Government, Mssolini, and the members of the Council, the final arbiters of what was to count as constitutional law for the nation. After the passage of the law of the Grand Council, not a vestige of the liberal parliamentary system remained. It is in that context that Gentile's comments are instructive.

It is impossible to allow the law of the Grand Council to pass without a few words of comment, since it has given rise to thousands of expositions and judgments by journalists of the entire world, and concerning which one might imagine that everything had been said. Its importance is such that everything that has been said is nothing compared to that with which history will concern itself. A constitutional law of this kind is the beginning of a new history, to which the journals allude. But it has not been from this point of view, in general, that the law has been considered.

There are two ways to consider and appraise a law: juridical and political. The second easily transforms itself into the first— since whoever speaks of the political significance of a law frequently closes with a consideration that is entirely juridical, from which the political spirit remains extrinsic.

The jurist considers the form of the law, its coherence, its relationship to the system of State laws. When one deals, as in the present case, with constitutional law, all the interests of the jurist concentrates itself on the examination of the compatibility or incompatibility of the new laws and the fundamental Statute.¹⁸

* Published in *Educazione fascista*, September 1928.

The political, on the other hand, looks toward the substance of the law—any law—which never limits itself exclusively to its technical content (finance, public health, economy, education, etc.), but conforms to the political reality to whose development all laws, more or less, contribute.

But true political considerations would not limit themselves, as is often the case, to the study of the relationship between political tendencies already defined, laws extant in legislative and institutional forms, and the new laws introduced into the juridical system of the State. In doing so, one returns from the political point of view to the juridical. The judgments tendered take on a formal and theoretical character, one might say retrospective character—for they define past as well as present reality. They are reflections on that reality. They do not simply accept past development, but rather commit themselves to the formation of a new consciousness—in whose realization consists the entire political life of a people—its evolving history. One does not undertake politics, or make history solely by promulgating new laws, creating new institutions, or winning battles, but also (and properly) by developing new spiritual attitudes, new ideas, and creating, in fact, new human beings and a new spirit.

Political considerations are not theoretical, but practical, in the most exquisite sense of the word. They look not to the past, but to the future. They are not animated by intellectualistic interests, conceptual or formal systematizations, but by a profound sense of the historic reality of the nation and its development. They therefore consider the real nucleus, the historically significant and actual substance of laws. Political considerations are never extraneous to the political form in which the process of national life, in its unity, finds expression.

Perhaps this has been too long a preamble—but it is not pointless in the present circumstances, considering that it might be of assistance to persons in recognizing the new political situation in which Italy finds itself since the 20th of September 1928. After that date, it was no longer appropriate to appeal to the categories of political judgments which had hitherto served in the daily polemics between Fascists and anti-Fascists about the Fascist revolution, and on which turned the contrast of the two terms equally vital and operative: Constitution and Revolution. It was a contrast which the Fascist regime sought to gradually resolve by constitutionalizing the Revolution. There arose at every step the opposition of the paladins of the

Constitution—directed against the representatives of the Revolution. Conversely, the followers of the Revolution were provoked to attack the institutions and the authority of the State organized in accordance with the old Constitutional norms. The last typical example of that contrast arose in the Senate around the electoral law—at which time the Head of the Government had reason to affirm, in concluding the debate, that Fascists and their adversaries spoke two different languages. They were different languages because the adversaries of Fascism raised a simple legal question (that involved above all the constitutional form of the Fascist Grand Council that was very active politically) while Fascists were occupied with singularly political issues.

Today, every equivocation has been eliminated. The Constitution has been fundamentally altered. The formal basis for any discussion by the constitutional jurists of the opposition has been removed. The liberals of one time who were the defenders of the Constitution and the State—in so far as the latter had its structure and its guarantee in the Constitution, and who presented themselves as the guardians of order—have now either abandoned the field or have assumed a posture diametrically opposed to the one previously held. This is true because the liberty they sought was never an abstract and anarchical individualistic liberty—it was the liberty of the individual within the State and within the fundamental laws of the State. That liberty, by virtue of the laws of the Grand Council, is now Fascist liberty, that is to say, the liberty of the citizen whose will is explicated and actuated through a new system of constitutional life. In that life, among other things, representation is no longer bicameral but tricameral. The third representative house, which concentrates and purifies every element of the national will that is singularly political, brings together and organizes every effective force that pretends to represent and interpret that will. That third house of representation, in accordance with the classical principle of every State constitution, shares power with the Monarchy. It is a power that is truly the result, and at the same time, the principle of State personality in which the national tradition and conservative interests reconcile themselves to the dynamism of popular life in its historic development.

The two major articles of the law are those that assign to the Grand Council the formation of the list of Deputies nominated to parliament, to be then subject to election by the nation.¹⁹ That is coupled

with the preparation of a list of counsellors from which the Crown might select the Head of Government.

The first article does not destroy, but establishes the popular and progressive character of national representation; and the second does not deny the King, as is proper in a monarchical State, the selection of a Head of Government with the assistance of his ministers—just as it was in the parliamentary system when the selection involved the advice of parliament. In fact, the new system reinforces the prerogatives of the Crown. If the fluctuating majority in parliament was, in fact, free of every limitation, directive, and corrective action of the Crown, in the new Fascist regime the constitution of the Grand Council is anything but the result of a *contingent* national will. All of its ordinary members receive the approval of the King. They are drawn from the hierarchical organization of all the spontaneous forces of national life. It is true that [in pre-Fascist times] parliamentary recommendations [to the King] was a practice and not specifically a constitutional right. Precisely for that reason it had an elasticity and an indeterminate character that, as we can observe in the experiment with proportionality, succeeded in entirely nullifying, in practice, the discretionary power in choice exercised by the Crown. Choice, in the old parliamentary system, became subject to the arbitrary play [of majorities produced by] various combinations of groups, including mercurial little groups. The new written law and the consequent discipline of the large numbers involved, compatible with the ulterior selection of the Sovereign, guarantees the compatibility of the national will with the supreme directive will of the Monarch. It provides a guarantee that tumult and lack of continuity will not disrupt the normal historical development of national life. [The new system provides for] liberty and order, progress as well as conservation of those vital and essential elements of the national organism—which are necessary, as is the case in every organism, if it is to develop. An organism cannot develop if it does not conserve and defend, unchanged and unchangeable, its fundamental nucleus and its living individuality.

The Fascist State possesses an acute awareness of its proper individuality—and, as a consequence, an equally solid and profound instinctive sense of its own conservation, together with a sense of its own power of development. It possesses a powerful concept of the absolute autonomy of its proper ethical personality and of the consequent continuity of its very being. All of which means that the

Fascist State opposes itself to every conception that would make it the result of contingencies. It conceives itself as the necessary principle and the origin of every value it acknowledges. In the Grand Council, as the vehicle of all those forces operating to sustain that State, it has fashioned an organ compatible with the Constitution. The Grand Council was initially created through the obscure instinct of great revolutionary forces. Through the Grand Council, the will of an extraordinarily gifted human being becomes an organic and enduring institution. That which appeared as an ordinary and contingent creation of an individual, becomes the constitutional structure of the nation. The hero depersonalizes himself and transforms himself into the spirit of his people—a spirit that organizes and disciplines all the energies necessary to sustain the new vital impulse from whence comes redemption—which has acquired consciousness of itself and of its proper destiny.

With the law of the Grand Council the Fascist Revolution completes its transformation and completely resolves itself in the State. The Party ceases to be a party among many. It sends its Secretary to the Council of Ministers. [The Party is no longer only a part of the forces that make up the governance of the nation.] As the organization of the great majority of the nation—or of the politically significant masses of the Italian people—the Party becomes the nation. Having brought forth the government out of itself, the government is recognized by the people and the people are governed by it. The minorities that remain at the margins of national life are, by the Party, through the Grand Council, made valuable insofar as they can make a moral contribution to that life. They are means or instruments, rather than the subjects of the political life of the nation. Political life truly coincides with the Party, insofar as it adheres to the Regime—or rather, to the spirit which informs and sustains the life of the nation. The Party is totalitarian in law and in fact—because politically, law prevails over fact and not vice versa.

With the constitutionalization of the Fascist Regime the new history begins in which all Italians are invited to collaborate under the emblem of the Lictor's Rods—no longer to be Fascists and anti-Fascists, but Italians—no longer revolutionaries or defenders of the old regime, but citizens of the new Italy, united in the common proposition that they all take part in the grandeur and power of the nation. Within the State there is liberty with discipline; outside the State there is nothing. Within the new laws every right is sacred, because

every right is a duty. It is a duty of the citizen to himself, because it is a duty to the Fatherland.

It is a new ideal, to which the Fascist Party is and must be responsible. The Fascist Party, in its triumph, feels the enormous weight of the responsibility it has assumed.

1928

Notes

1. Over the years the Italian parliament, through custom, had become responsible for the declaration of war. On the occasion of the declaration of war in 1915, the king had restored that power to himself.
2. See Giuseppe Mazzini, *The Duties of Man and Other Essays* (London: J. M. Dent, 1912) and Bolton King, *The Life of Mazzini* (London: J. M. Dent, 1914).
3. See Gentile's treatment of the thought of the Risorgimento, with its emphasis on that of Giuseppe Mazzini. Gentile, *Albori della nuova Italia: Varietà e documenti* (Lanciano: Carabba, 1923), Parts 1 and 2.
4. See Gentile, *Rosmini e Gioberti: Saggio storico sulla filosofia italiana del Risorgimento* (Florence: Sansoni, 1958).
5. See the entire discussion in Gentile, *Le origini della filosofia contemporanea in Italia* (Messina: Giuseppe Principato, 1917) in three parts.
6. Gentile always capitalized the term "State." That practice will be followed throughout the translations.
7. See the account of the period provided by Alfredo Oriani, *La lotta politica in Italia* (Rocca San Casciano: Cappelli, 1956), Books 8 and 9. Gentile approved of Oriani's account. See Mussolini's assessment of Oriani's work in his "Preface" to Alfredo Oriani, *La rivolta ideale* (Bologna: Cappelli, 1943), pp. iii-v.
8. Gentile's reform of education in 1923 restored religious education to the elementary schools in Italy.
9. Under the Fascist regime, Masonry was to be suppressed; see Alfredo Rocco, "Le leggi di difesa," *La trasformazione dello stato: Dallo stato liberale allo stato fascista* (Rome: "La Voce," 1927), pp. 35-58.
10. See Giuseppe Mazzini, "To the Italian Working Class" and "To The Italians," *The Duties of Man and Other Essays*, pp. 1-3, 221-247.
11. See the account of Ardigò, one of the principal positivists of the period. Giovanni Marchesini, *Roberto Ardigò: L'uomo e l'umanista* (Florence: Felice le Monnier, 1922).
12. See Gentile, *Studi vichiani* (Florence: Felice le Monnier, 1927).
13. See Gentile, *Il modernismo e i rapporti fra religione e filosofia* (Florence: Sansoni, 1962).
14. In this context see the exposition of Curzio Malaparte when he wrote as "the most formidable pen of Fascism," in Curzio Malaparte, "L'Europa vivente," in *L'Europa vivente e altri saggi politici (1921-1931)* (Florence: Vallecchi, 1961). In terms of the Fascist conception of revolutionary violence, see the exposition in Sergio Panunzio, *Diritto, forza e violenza: Lineamenti di una teoria della violenza* (Bologna: Cappelli, 1921); for a discursive account of Panunzio's views, see A. James Gregor, "Some Thoughts on State and Rebel Terror," in David C. Rapoport and Yonah Alexander (eds.), *The Rationalization of Terrorism* (Frederick, MD.: Aletheia

- Books, 1982), pp. 56-66. For comparative purposes, see Leon Trotsky, *Terrorism and Communism* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, 1961).
15. This was one form of the armed political party that characterizes one category of revolutionary parties. The Nazi SS was another form. The Red Army, and the People's Liberation Army, still others.
 16. In this context, see Gentile, "Mazzini e la Nuova Italia," "Risorgimento e fascismo," and "Il pensiero italiano del secolo XIX," in *Memorie italiane e problemi della filosofia e della vita* (Florence: Sansoni, 1936), pp. 23-42, 115-120, 221-244.
 17. In this context, see Gentile, *Manzoni and Leopardi: Saggi critici* (Milan: Treves, 1928).
 18. At the time of the revisions of the Statuto of 1848 by which Italy was governed until the Fascist reforms, constitutional reform could be conducted "piecemeal" by means of ordinary legislation. The *Statuto* contained 84 brief articles that were simply broad declarations of principle. As the *Statuto* matured through practice, there was no Italian court charged with the responsibility of passing on the constitutionality of acts adopted by parliament or promulgated by the monarch. Once Mussolini received, from the Italian parliament, the power to decree legislation, he could transform the *Statuto* by integrating and adjusting legislation to meet the ends of Fascism. In 1928, Mussolini had Italian law take cognizance of a distinction between "ordinary" and "constitutional" legislation when the Fascist Grand Council was made a major agency of the State, and afforded the power of passing on all "questions having a constitutional character." The Grand Council, chosen by Mussolini (and confirmed by the King), thus became a central organ of the State.
 19. The similarities with the system that had emerged in Stalin's Soviet Union require no comment.